

[North America](#) > [United States](#) > [Pacific Northwest](#) > [Washington \(state\)](#) > [Puget Sound](#) > [King County](#) > [Seattle](#)

Seattle

Seattle, [Washington](#) sits at one of the most beautiful spots in the [United States](#). Occupying a narrow isthmus between the Puget Sound and Lake Washington, it is the biggest city in the [Pacific Northwest](#), with 780,000 people in Seattle and over four million people in the metro area. Seen from above, carpets of evergreen trees, pristine blue waters, and snowy white mountains surround the downtown's metallic skyscrapers, earning the city its nickname **The Emerald City**.

On the ground, you will find a vibrant and cosmopolitan city. Next to the progressive downtown and the freewheeling feel of Capitol Hill, you can find a laid-back atmosphere in the districts to the north and ethnically diverse neighborhoods to the south. The many restaurants, coffee shops and microbreweries are worth indulging in after a day spent strolling through the city's many parks and beaches or admiring the arts and architecture. At the same time, around the shores of Lake Union and out east in Bellevue, are some of the most competitive megacorporations in modern American Society, as the city is home to Amazon, Microsoft, and Boeing. And just outside the hectic city are snow-covered mountains, evergreen forests, and stunning coastline to explore. Even for the bold and the adventurous, it's hard to get enough of Seattle.

Welcome World Cup fans

Seattle is one of the 16 North American cities hosting matches for the [2026 FIFA World Cup](#), between June 15 and July 6. Games here will be played at **Lumen Field** (also called *Seattle Stadium* for this event), south of Downtown and Pioneer Square in the [SoDo District](#). Here are a few helpful tips for visiting fans:

- See the official **Seattle FIFA World Cup website** (<https://www.seattlefwc26.org/>) for day-by-day game and event schedules.
- Lumen Field is about 12 mi (19 km) north of [Seattle–Tacoma International Airport \(SEA\)](#). A taxi or Uber ride usually takes 20–35 minutes, and Link light rail takes about 35 minutes.
- The most convenient **hotels** are in [Downtown Seattle](#), especially around Pioneer Square, Belltown and the Waterfront. These areas are within 15 minutes from the stadium by taxi or Uber, walkable, lively and filled with cafés, bars and restaurants. Fans looking for a more neighborhood atmosphere may prefer the [University District](#) or [Capitol Hill](#), both of which offer plenty of dining options and a youthful vibe. If the centrally-located hotels are booked out, any lodging within walking distance of a suburban light rail station (such as [Bellevue](#), [Lynnwood](#) or [SeaTac Airport](#)) is within 45 minutes of the stadium.
- **Link light rail** connects the airport, Downtown and Lumen Field at **Stadium Station** and **International District/Chinatown Station**, making it one of the easiest ways to reach Lumen Field on match days. Buses and streetcars link Downtown and Pioneer Square to all

other parts of the city, though **Uber** and **Lyft** are widely available and are often more convenient for longer trips.

Districts

Seattle does not have official neighborhood boundaries, because Seattle does not have any officially-designated neighborhoods! However, most of the informally defined neighborhoods are widely known and agreed upon amongst Seattleites. Many are defined by a proud feature or a prominent street.

Many visitors to Seattle do not venture beyond Downtown, the International District, and the Seattle Center. That's a shame, since neighborhoods like Capitol Hill, West Seattle, and those north of the ship canal are where much of the fun actually is!

Downtown and surrounding neighborhoods

Downtown

Seattle's commercial and financial core, home to the waterfront, the Pike Place Market, and some of the most stunning architecture in the city. The northern area of Belltown has a collection of many of the city's best, if not most expensive, restaurants and bars.

Pioneer Square and International District

The oldest neighborhoods of Seattle, containing classic buildings, art galleries, innumerable restaurants, and the Chinatown.

Queen Anne and South Lake Union

Perched on the hills northwest of Downtown, here you will find wealthy neighborhoods peppered with panoramic parks. On the area's south is the newly developed commercial center of South Lake Union (home of the rapidly growing Amazon headquarters), and the **Seattle Center** with its Space Needle.

Capitol Hill and Central District

The nightlife and retail core of Pike-Pine at the west meets the quiet, diverse residences of Madison Park at the east. This area is also the gay capital of Seattle.



North of the Lake Washington Ship Canal

Ballard

A mostly residential area, home to the canal locks. The area is known for its Scandinavian heritage, chic boutiques, and the thriving historic Downtown Ballard.

Fremont and Wallingford

The self-proclaimed "center of the universe", a bohemian (though rapidly gentrifying) area noted for its public art.

University District (commonly called the "U District")

Home to the sprawling University of Washington campus, numerous inexpensive eateries, and plenty of entertainment.

North Seattle

The city's mostly residential and gently gentrifying northernmost tier, bordering Shoreline. It contains many of the largest and prettiest parks of Seattle. Noticeable commercial activity is present in the Northgate, Aurora, and Lake City neighborhoods.

South of Downtown and I-90

SoDo and Georgetown

Continuing south of Downtown past the sports stadiums, this industrial district contains the well-hidden but thriving Georgetown neighborhood.

South Seattle

A mostly residential area bordering Lake Washington, served by light rail and home to Jefferson and Seward Parks. The Columbia City neighborhood is probably its liveliest.

West Seattle

A scenic residential area with great parks, ample beaches and wonderful vistas over the harbor and Downtown.

While in Seattle you will likely hear reference to the "**Eastside**", which refers to the region east of Lake Washington comprising the suburbs of Bellevue, Kirkland, and Redmond.

Understand

History

The first humans are believed to have entered the region nearly 4,000 years ago. Englishman George Vancouver mapped the area in the 1790s, but the first white settlers didn't arrive until 1851. Luther Collins led a party of settlers to the mouth of the Duwamish River (in what is today southern Seattle), followed shortly by a party led by the more notable Arthur A. Denny of Chicago, who settled at Alki Point in West Seattle. Confrontations between the original settlers initially flared, only to die out as the groups settled together on the Elliott Bay. The area was then named Seattle by David Maynard, in honor of **Chief Si'ahl** of the Duwamish & Suquamish tribes, and later officially established as a city in 1869.

By the 1880s, development of a modern city came to life with the erection of buildings, a streetcar system, and a lumber mill at the end of a timber skid row (what is now Yesler Way), only to be destroyed by fire in 1889. The city came alive again in 1897 during the **Klondike Gold Rush**, when Seattle served as the departure city for miners bound for Alaska and the Yukon. Entire hills were sluiced into Elliott Bay to make flat land for development, and the Lake

Washington Ship Canal was dug to connect Lake Washington to the Puget Sound. Beyond the gold rush alone, Seattle became a transshipment point in this era, for instance for the Alaskan salmon trade, a role it still plays to this day.

The city's economy slowed down again during the Great Depression, but experienced a renewed fervor starting in World War II, as the Boeing aircraft company emerged as a major manufacturer and largest employer in the region. Seattle hosted the **1962 World's Fair**, which opened the gates for modernization of the city. By then, Seattle had practically become a company town for Boeing, leaving it vulnerable to its cyclical downturns, particularly during the 1970s oil crisis.

The software industry was about to make a big impact on the city, foreshadowed by **Microsoft's** move from Albuquerque to the Seattle area in the early 1980s. Soon, **Amazon, Nintendo of America, T-Mobile, Starbucks**, and numerous biotech companies established themselves, bringing an influx of population growth and money into the area. Today, the Seattle metropolitan area's wealth and its four million inhabitants (more than half of the population of Washington State) make it the economic powerhouse of the Pacific Northwest and one of the world's largest technology hubs.

Culture

Multiculturalism is seen as a virtue. White people make up about 70% of the population, while more than a tenth of Seattleites are of Asian descent. English is spoken virtually everywhere in the city but there are ethnic areas in South Seattle where Vietnamese and Tagalog are also commonly spoken, as well as Chinese and Japanese in the International District. In particular, Seattle has long been known for its large Taiwanese community. The ZIP code 98118 in South Seattle is one of the most ethnically diverse neighborhoods in the entire United States!

Being a *very* politically left-wing part of the country, Seattle has one of the most sprawling **LGBTQ+** communities in the U.S., second only to San Francisco. While the vast majority of Seattle businesses are LGBTQ+-friendly, the Capitol Hill area, east of downtown, is the main place for LGBTQ+-focused business and bars, as well as a resource center. A large PrideFest takes place annually at the Seattle Center, along with preceding events such as a Pride Parade. The city is also home to a number of other annual Pride events, including the Seattle Dyke March and Capitol Hill Pride.

Locals and visitors alike have long remarked of the **Seattle Freeze**, referring to the cold politeness of residents. While they are polite and welcoming on first interaction, they are actually reserved, and interactions rarely lead to deeper acts of friendship (an invitation to dinner, personal conversations, etc.). The origin is obscure, but it is mostly attributed to Scandinavian immigrants that brought their home country's customs here, including this form of introversion. Expect to have to make all the "first moves" to meet people here. This shyness also extends to anger and annoyance. Locals often make fun of themselves for their passive-aggressive culture, where they will retain their polite nature even in the most upsetting circumstances.

Climate

The stereotype of Seattle weather is that it is **Rain City**, where the sky is always grey, rainy, and depressing. Despite the reputation, the main challenge of Seattle's weather is more the overcast skies than the rain, and in fact Seattle has less annual rainfall than most cities east of the Rocky Mountains. Seattle's rain usually comes in a drizzle that lingers for days, which only occasionally strengthens to a full-blown torrent that rarely lasts long. Many residents call this period of overcast "the season of grey" as it lasts from late October to early March every year. The season is also accompanied by the short daylight hours of the winter, where its only light out from 7:45AM to 4:30PM.

It may surprise you that **rain is virtually absent from July through September**, making Seattle an excellent place to spend

summer. It's warm and comfortable a decent amount of the time, with little to moderate humidity, with average summer highs of 79 °F (26 °C) and lows of 59 °F (15 °C). However, there are sometimes occasional days of high heat where temperatures and heat indices can climb up to or even exceed 89 °F (32 °C) and not go below 64 °F (18 °C) at night. Furthermore, because of Seattle's high latitude, there is daylight from around 5:15AM to 9PM during the summer months, giving you ample daylight for outdoor activities.

Despite its location as the northernmost big city in the U.S., **winters in Seattle are mild** compared to most other places in the northern half of the country. Marine air from the Puget Sound and the Pacific Ocean moderates Seattle's climate, so that freezes are uncommon and most precipitation falls as rain instead of snow. The city typically sees only one or two snowfalls a year.

The area's complex topography creates substantial **microclimates**. It can be raining in the city itself but sunny five miles north or snowing in heaps fifteen miles inland to the Cascade foothills, often puzzling weather forecasters.

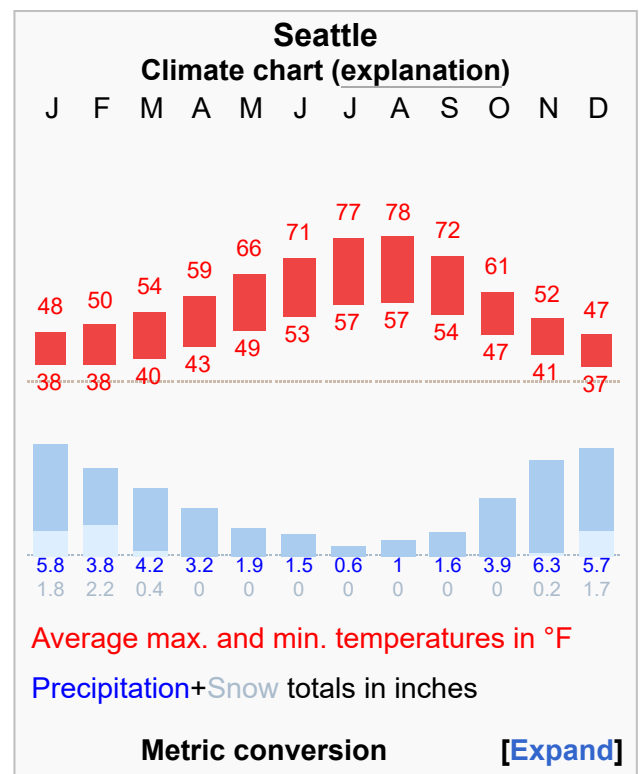
Read

- *The Art of Racing in the Rain*, by Garth Stein, is a New York Times bestseller about a race car driver told from the perspective of his dog, Enzo.

Watch

As might be expected, nearly all movies and TV shows set in Seattle feature at least an establishing shot of the Space Needle.

- Many people will still remember the sitcom *Frasier*, which ran for 11 seasons until 2004. The *Cheers* spin-off followed the life of the Crane family: Frasier Crane, a radio psychiatrist, his



brother Niles, his father Martin, and his assistant, Daphne Moon. Although most of the show was actually filmed in studios in Los Angeles, the 100th episode was shot for real on the streets of Seattle, the monorail, and the Seattle Center.

- The medical drama *Grey's Anatomy* is set in Seattle to distinguish it from its counterpart, Chicago's *ER*. Fisher Plaza, home to the ABC-affiliated KOMO radio and television station and right across the street from the Space Needle, serves as the exterior of the fictional Grey-Sloan Memorial Hospital.
- *It Happened at the World's Fair* (Norman Taurog, 1963). Elvis Presley stars as Mike, a cropduster pilot who hitchhikes with his friend Danny (Gary Lockwood) into Seattle during the 1962 World's Fair, where he meets his love interest, played by Joan O'Brien.
- *The Parallax View* (Alan J. Pakula, 1974). Released at the height of the political paranoia of the 70s, this film follows an investigative reporter (played by Warren Beatty) who discovers a secretive corporation that recruits political assassins. There's a lot of excellent Seattle imagery in this film, and the movie is well-remembered for its opening assassination scene that takes place atop the Space Needle.
- *Singles* (Cameron Crowe, 1992). A romantic comedy about two young couples experiencing rocky love while living in a Seattle apartment block. The film was particularly noted for its grunge soundtrack, coming on the heels of Seattle's grunge music boom. The central coffee shop in the film is at the now-closed OK Hotel in Pioneer Square, and the apartment used in the movie is at the northwest corner of E. Thomas St & 19th Ave E.
- *Sleepless In Seattle* (Nora Ephron, 1993). Tom Hanks plays Sam Baldwin, a widower father searching for comfort in Seattle after the loss of his wife. After his young son, Jonah, calls a radio station for help, a woman (Meg Ryan) develops an attraction to Sam. Sam Baldwin's houseboat is set on Lake Union, which is worth a visit for fans of the movie.

Music

Seattle is most well-known for **grunge**, a combination of punk and metal performed by Nirvana, Pearl Jam, Soundgarden, and many other Seattle-based groups. The genre emerged and slowly grew through the mid-1980s before exploding to international fame in 1991 with the release of Nirvana's breakthrough album *Nevermind*, but its prominence came to an end after singer Kurt Cobain's shocking suicide in 1994.

Seattle has had a long, diverse and tolerant music history from early on, including a politically radical American folk scene in the 1920s to a thriving post-war jazz scene that boomed in many clubs throughout the area. Grunge was heavily influenced by the counterculture music scene that dominated Seattle from the mid-1970s through the 1980s, with such noted acts as a gay glam theater group called Ze Whiz Kids and bands like The Telepaths, The Beakers, and Red Dress (the last of which is still active as of 2023). Seattle also has another musical claim to fame in native son **Jimi Hendrix**, although he found his success in England; nevertheless, this hasn't stopped Seattle from erecting a statue of him in Capitol Hill and devoting an entire section to Hendrix at the Museum of Pop Culture in the Seattle Center.

Local favorite radio station *KEXP* is a great source for alternative and experimental music and has helped launch the careers of not only grunge bands like Nirvana but local **hip hop** favorites such as Macklemore, Ryan Lewis, and the Blue Scholars, as well as many other nationally known **alternative bands** such as Sunny Day Real Estate, Modest Mouse, The Postal Service, Death Cab for Cutie, Band of Horses, The Head and the Heart and Fleet Foxes.

Tourist information

The **Seattle Convention and Visitors Bureau** operates two visitors centers. Both offer maps, brochures, event details, tour bookings, and restaurant reservations:

- **Seattle Visitors Center and Concierge Services** (<https://visitseattle.org>), 701 Pike Street, Suite 800 (*inside the Seattle Convention Center's Arch Building*). Daily 9AM-5PM during summer, M-F 9AM-5PM during winter.
- **Market Information Center** (<https://visitseattle.org>), 1st and Pike (*on the southwest corner*). Daily 10AM-6PM.



A view of the Seattle waterfront



Get in

By plane

Main article: [Seattle-Tacoma International Airport](#)

1 **Seattle-Tacoma International Airport** (<https://www.portseattle.org/sea-tac#>) (**SEA**^{IATA}), 17801 International Blvd, SeaTac, ☎ +1 206-787-5388, toll-free: +1-800-544-1965. Nicknamed "Sea-Tac", is in the city's southern suburbs 14 mi (23 km) south of downtown Seattle. It's a major domestic hub for Alaska, Northwest and West Coast destinations, and also handles many international trans-Pacific routes, as well as some flights to major European and Middle East airports. In addition, the airport is well-connected to virtually every part of the US, with multiple daily flights to many major US cities, as well as to Alaska and Hawaii. (updated Oct 2023 |) Alaska Airlines (<https://www.alaskaair.com>) uses this airport as its primary hub and is by far the biggest carrier here, with Delta (<https://www.delta.com>) catching up with an international hub here and an increasing number of domestic destinations.

The reliable **Link light rail 1 Line** (<https://www.soundtransit.org/ride-with-us/routes-schedules/>) (see § *Get around*) connects Sea-Tac to many points north, including South Seattle, Downtown, Capitol Hill, University of Washington, Northgate, Shoreline, Mountlake Terrace, and Lynnwood. Sound Transit bus route 560 (<https://www.soundtransit.org/schedules/st-express-bus/560>) provides direct service from Sea-Tac to West Seattle.

A longer, yet cheaper way to cross Canada

Travelers who are traveling between Eastern Canada and western Canada (especially Vancouver) can make use of the cheaper fares when flying to or from Seattle-Tacoma International Airport before transferring by bus, due to favoritism and high taxes that make Canadian domestic air travel expensive (see [Vancouver: Get In](#)). Allow at least an additional 3 hours for transfer between transportation modes and travel across the border. Remember to have a passport (and visa if necessary) with you because you will be traveling between international borders.

Alternate airports

2 Paine Field (<https://www.flypaineairport.com>) (PAE^{IATA}), also known as Snohomish County Airport, about 30 mi (48 km) north of Seattle in Everett, serves limited commercial flights from Alaska Airlines from the western half of the continental US. The terminal, ranked one of the best regional airports in the world, has a rather cozy design with fireplaces and nice chairs and sofas, and waiter service from the restaurants available throughout the terminal (all two gates of it). Everett Transit provides service to a transit hub at Everett Mall, where buses to the region can be found.

The much-smaller **Bellingham International Airport (<https://www.portofbelllingham.com/888/Airport>) (BLI^{IATA})**, 94 mi (151 km) (about 90 minutes drive) north of Seattle in Bellingham, can be used as an alternative to fly into Seattle, despite the scarcity of flights. Low-cost carrier Allegiant Air (<https://www.allegiantair.com/airports/Bellingham-International-Airport>) flies to Bellingham from Las Vegas, Los Angeles, Oakland, Palm Springs, Phoenix-Mesa and Oakland. They do not fly into or out of Seattle-Tacoma International Airport. Alaska Airlines (<https://www.alaskaair.com/content/airports/washington/bellingham/bellingham-international>) flies up, only from Seattle-Tacoma only. On the ground Quickcoach (<https://www.quickcoach.com>) offers connections to/from Vancouver, BC while Bel Air Airporter (<http://www.airporter.com>) goes to/from Seattle-Tacoma International Airport via downtown Seattle (Convention Center). This airport also serves as a gateway point to travel to the San Juan Islands by air with San Juan Airlines (<https://sanjuanairlines.com>)

Portland International Airport (<https://www.flypdx.com>) (PDX^{IATA}), 160 mi (260 km) (about 3 hours drive) south of Seattle in Portland, is a major airport, but smaller than Sea-Tac, and is another alternative to fly into Seattle, especially with low-cost carriers Allegiant Air (<http://www.allegiantair.com/en/flights-to-portland-or>) and Volaris (<https://www.volaris.com>) (flights from Mexico). There are no direct shuttle services from Portland International Airport to Seattle, but there are Greyhound and Amtrak services from downtown Portland to downtown Seattle. In addition Alaska Airlines, SeaPort Airlines (<https://www.flyseaportair.com/>) (to Boeing Field (BFI)), and Delta Connection offer frequent daily direct flights between Portland and Seattle.

Vancouver International Airport (<https://www.yvr.ca/en/passengers>) (YVR^{IATA}), 140 mi (230 km) (about 2 hr 30 min drive) north of Seattle across the border in Canada, is another major airport, and well-served by flights from East Asia. The downside is that you will have to go through customs and immigration twice, and if required for your nationality, you will also need to obtain a visa for Canada. Alaska Airlines, Air Canada and Delta Connection offer frequent daily direct flights between Vancouver and Seattle.

Private aircraft and seaplane

Private aircraft can use **3 King County International Airport (<https://www.kingcounty.gov/services/airport.aspx>) (BFI^{IATA})**, universally known as **Boeing Field**. It's also south of the city, but much closer to town than Sea-Tac airport. There is limited commercial passenger service with Kenmore Air (<https://kenmoreair.com>) in its small passenger terminal at 7277 Perimeter Rd (location of marker). Customs and immigration available for international arrivals with prior arrangement.

The aforementioned **Paine Field** in Everett is another popular option for general aviation.

Seaplane service is available between Seattle and various island destinations throughout Washington state and British Columbia. **Kenmore Air** (<https://kenmoreair.com/>) operates year-round scheduled floatplane services from their terminal on Lake Union to the San Juan Islands and Victoria, and summer flights from their base at Kenmore on Lake Washington's north end to Nanaimo, Campbell River and many other destinations in northern British Columbia. **Harbour Air** (<https://harbourair.com>) also operates flights from Lake Union to Victoria (55 mins; \$385). Wheeled plane service is also offered from Boeing Field to Friday Harbor and Eastsound airports. A ground shuttle service is available from the Lake Union and Boeing Field terminals to Sea-Tac.



Kenmore Air floatplane arriving at a terminal on Lake Union

4 Renton Municipal Airport (https://www.rentonwa.gov/city_hall/public_works/renton_municipal_airport) (**RNT**^{IATA}), farther from downtown than Boeing Field but still closer than Sea-Tac Airport, is another option for general aviation, with a sea plane dock at the north end of the airport on Lake Washington known as Wiley Post Memorial Seaplane Base. This airport only has basic facilities and no terminal building, but customs and immigration facilities are available for international arrivals with prior arrangement. Air charter companies fly a variety of private charter aircraft and jets for small groups and individuals.

By train

See also: [Rail travel in the United States](#)

 **5 King Street station** (<https://www.amtrak.com/stations/sea>), 303 S King St (south of downtown near Lumen Field and across the street from the International District / Chinatown Link light rail station). (updated Sep 2022 |)

- **Amtrak** (<https://www.amtrak.com/>), ☎ +1 215-856-7924, toll-free: +1-800-872-7245. Operates train service around the United States. (updated Mar 2022 |) Routes stopping in Seattle:

- **Amtrak Cascades** operates between Vancouver, BC and Eugene via Bellingham, Mount Vernon, Everett, Edmonds, Seattle, Tukwila, Tacoma, Lacey (Olympia), Centralia, Kelso (Longview), Vancouver, WA, Portland, Oregon City, Salem, and Albany. There are two round trips daily along the portion between Vancouver and Seattle, six round trips daily along the portion between Seattle and Portland, and two round trips daily along the portion between Portland and Eugene. No train departures travel the whole length of the route. Travel time to Seattle from Eugene is 6.25 hours, from Portland is 3.5 hours, from Tacoma is 55 minutes, from Bellingham is 2.5 hours, and from Vancouver, BC is 4.5 hours. Additional service between Vancouver and Seattle, and between Portland to Eugene are provided on the Amtrak Thruway Bus. Additional service from Portland to Eugene and from Seattle to Vancouver is offered on the Amtrak Thruway Motorcoach. These trains are more reliable schedule-wise than the long distance trains and offer certain amenities not



Historic King Street Station

available on regular Amtrak trains, such as more space for bikes, more laptop outlets, a "Bistro Car" which serves local foods and wine, and the occasional movie.

- **Coast Starlight** operates daily between Seattle and Los Angeles. Stops include Tacoma, Portland, Eugene, Klamath Falls, Dunsmuir, Redding, Chico, Sacramento, Davis, Martinez, San Francisco (Emeryville), Oakland, San Jose, Salinas, Paso Robles, San Luis Obispo, Santa Barbara, Oxnard, Simi Valley, Van Nuys, and Burbank. Between Seattle and Eugene, it makes the same stops as the Amtrak Cascades, except it skips Tukwila and Oregon City. Travel time to Seattle from Portland is 4 hours, from Eugene is 7.25 hours, from Sacramento is 20 hours, from Emeryville is 22.25 hours, from San Jose is 1 day, and from Los Angeles is 1 day 10 hours.
- **Empire Builder**, a long-distance sleeper train, which also runs daily between Seattle and Chicago including stops in Edmonds, Everett, Leavenworth, Wenatchee, Ephrata, Spokane, Sandpoint, Glacier National Park, Fargo, Saint Paul, and Milwaukee. The trains split into separate branches between Seattle and Spokane, and between Portland and Spokane, while operating as trains consisting of train cars from both branches between Spokane and Chicago. Travel time to Seattle from Spokane is 8 hour, from West Glacier (Glacier National Park) is 15 hours, from Minneapolis is 1 day 14.25 hours, from Milwaukee is 1 day 20.75 hours, from Chicago is 1 day 22.5 hours.
- **Sounder** (<https://www.soundtransit.org/ride-with-us/routes-schedules/s-line>) trains, operated by Sound Transit, connect several of Seattle's northern and southern suburbs to King Street station. They generally run commuter-oriented schedules, but sometimes run additional services, such as for sports events. Sounder trains run to Seattle on weekday mornings, and from Seattle back to the suburbs in the evenings, although there are a limited number of reverse-commute runs. Trains travel south from Everett, Mukilteo, and Edmonds, and north from Lakewood, Tacoma, Puyallup, Sumner, Auburn, Kent, and Tukwila.

By car

 **Interstate 5** (I-5) is the major north-south roadway entering the city and the most direct way to drive from Vancouver or Portland. This roadway is notoriously congested through Downtown, even during non-commuting hours.

 **Interstate 405** (I-405) runs parallel to I-5 through the **Eastside** suburbs on the opposite side of Lake Washington, from Tukwila to Lynnwood through Renton, Bellevue, Kirkland and Woodinville.

 **Interstate 90** (I-90) is the only long-distance route to access Seattle from the east, and is the easiest way to reach Spokane and Eastern Washington. During the winter months, drivers must be mindful of the weather conditions over **Snoqualmie Pass**, 52 mi (84 km) east of the city, when the roadway can close unexpectedly due to weather conditions.

 to  Access to **State Route 599** (SR-599) is only accessible from the northbound (NB) lanes of I-5 at Exit 156 south of Seattle. SR-599 becomes SR-99 at its junction with Tukwila International Blvd. It continues north through Georgetown and SoDo along the Duwamish River and under downtown Seattle through the Viaduct Tunnel. From north of downtown Seattle, SR-99 goes up through Ballard and North Seattle as N Aurora Ave and eventually into Snohomish County via Aurora Village in Shoreline. It's also another way to reach West Seattle and Whitecenter from the south at the SR 99/509 junction via Highland Park Way SW.

520 State Route 520 (SR-520) also crosses Lake Washington, from Exit 168B of I-5 to Bellevue, Kirkland, and Redmond. The Evergreen Point Floating Bridge, the world's largest floating bridge, is tolled with rates that vary by the time of day. There are no toll booths. If the vehicle has a **"Good to Go" sticker** (<https://mygoodtogo.com/EN/>) on the windshield, the toll is deducted from a prepaid account. Otherwise, transponders take a picture of the license plates, front and back, and mail the bill to the registered owner.

522 State Route 522 (SR-522) comes from Exit 171 of I-5 as Lake City Way towards I-405 in Woodinville, around the northern shores of Lake Washington.

By bus

Except for Greyhound Lines, there is no designated long-distance bus terminal in Seattle, so all bus services have their own stops in different parts of the city. A number of them do have stops at the **Greyhound Terminal** (503 S Royal Brougham Way), in front of the **King Street Station** at 303 S King St and/or at Door 00 (south end at lower level of the terminal) at the **Sea-Tac airport**. See below:

- **6 BellAir Airporter** (<https://www.airporter.com/shuttle>), (bus stops) Seattle Tacoma International Airport, Washington State Convention Center, Convention Place (prior reservations only), ☎ +1-866-235-5247. Goes up to Stanwood, Burlington/Mt Vernon, Bellingham & Blaine on one route, a separate route to Anacortes in the San Juan Islands, and from Sea-Tac to Cle Elum, Ellensburg & Yakima on another route.
- **7 Cantrail/Amtrak Cascades Thruway** (<https://www.cantrail.com>), (bus stop) King Street Station, ☎ +1 604-294-5541, toll-free: +1-877-940-5561. Operates between Seattle and Vancouver, BC. Northbound buses pick-up in the U.S. and drop off in Canada while Southbound buses pick-up in Canada and drop off in the U.S. only. Travel time to Seattle from Vancouver, BC is 3.75-4 hours. \$40 for one-way, \$75 round trip; discounts for students, military, seniors & children ages 4-11.
- **Flixbus** (<https://www.flixbus.com/bus/seattle-wa>) (operated by Greyhound, MTR Western & Wenatchee Shuttle), (bus stops) 622 S Lane St for the Bellingham to Eugene bus; and in Seattle Tacoma International Airport "Airporters" bus zone for buses to Wenatchee (*Bus will board on the bus loading curb on South Lane St. Look for the "charter bus only" signs. Stop is across the street from (east of) Uwajimaya Market in the International District.*), ☎ +1 509 293-5773. Operates several daily departures to North Bend, Wenatchee and Peshastin from Sea-Tac (operated by Wenatchee Shuttle) and Bellevue. They also have another route from Seattle to Eugene via Tacoma, Olympia, Portland and Corvallis and to Spokane via Ellensburg and Moses Lake that are operated by MTR Western. \$45 one-way, \$85 roundtrip. (updated Jan 2018 |)
- **8 Greyhound Lines** (<https://www.greyhound.com/en-us/bus-station-780780>), (bus station) 503 S Royal Brougham Way, SoDo (*Along Royal Brougham between 6th Ave & the "Stadium" Light Rail Station. A right turn at Royal Brougham from the light rail station, opposite side of the tracks.*), ☎ +1 206 624-0618, toll-free: +1-800-231-2222. Daily 5AM-5PM. Greyhound travels primarily on I-5 (Vancouver-Seattle-Portland-Sacramento. Some southbound buses continue to Los Angeles contiguously), 90/82 (Seattle-Ellensburg-Yakima-Pasco-Stanfield, OR) & 90 (Seattle-Spokane). Passengers transfer to other buses in Portland, Pasco, Spokane, Ellensburg, or Denver (via Stanfield, Boise, Salt Lake City) to get to other cities & towns in the U.S. A route also travels to Vancouver, BC in Canada and another to Port Angeles via Edmonds-Kingston ferry on the 'Dungeness Line' bus. Travel time to Seattle from Portland is 3.5-4 hours, from Spokane is 7.75 hours, and from Vancouver, BC is 4.25 hours. Passengers transfer to Link Light Rail from 'Stadium Station', next to the bus station, to go north towards Lynnwood via downtown, University District/UW,

Ravenna, Northgate or any bus going north on the adjacent 'Bus Way' road to get into downtown. Take the southbound Link Light Rail to go towards the airport from the bus station via South Seattle. Prices vary depending on your destination.

- **Travel Washington Dungeness Line (<https://dungeness-line.com/>)** (Operated by Greyhound Connect), (bus stops) Greyhound bus depot (see above), King Street Station, selected hospitals (by reservation only), SeaTac Airport, ☎ +1 360 417-0700. Connects Seattle to Port Townsend, Sequim and Port Angeles. This bus also serves as an Amtrak Thruway connection to the Olympic Peninsula. The bus goes across the Puget Sound on the Edmonds-Kingston ferry. They also pick-up and drop off at the major hospitals, west of downtown, with an advance 24 hr reservation (Arnold Medical Pavilion, Harborview, Poly-Clinic Madison, VA, Swedish First Hill and Virginia Mason Buck Pavillion). One way: \$39 from downtown, \$49 from airport; Round trip: \$69 from downtown, \$79 from airport.
- **Northwestern Stage Lines (<https://northwesternstagelines.com/bus-stops/>)** (Northwest Trailways/Salt Lake City Express), (bus stops) Greyhound bus depot & King Street Amtrak station, toll-free: +1-800-366-3830. Shuttle service to Spokane (via Everett, Stevens Pass, Leavenworth, Wenatchee, George, Moses Lake, Ritzville) . Tickets can also be booked with Salt Lake City Express (<https://saltlakeexpress.com/>) and Megabus (<https://us.megabus.com>). \$51 one way to Spokane, \$97 round trip.
- **9 Quick Shuttle (<https://quickcoach.com>)**, (bus stops) downtown: outside the Best Western at 200 Taylor Ave N; Pier 66 & 91, SeaTac Airport: At the main terminal near south end of baggage claim, outside door 00, bays 11-16. Runs between Seattle and Vancouver, BC. Travel time to downtown Seattle from Vancouver, BC is 4.75 hours. Vancouver to Downtown Seattle: \$36 one-way, \$65 round-trip; Vancouver to SeaTac airport: \$49 one-way, \$87 round-trip. Despite the multiple stops they make, northbound buses can only pick-up in the U.S. and drop off in Canada and vice versa for southbound buses.
- **Wheatland Express (<https://starlinecollection.com/wheatland-express/>)** (Starline Collections), (bus stops) Southcenter, NW corner; Novilhos Brazilian Steak House, 12405 SE 38th Street, Bellevue, toll-free: +1-800-334-2207. Every Friday, the Weekend Express takes you from Pullman (where Washington State University is at) and Moscow to Seattle, and the other way round every Sunday. A special service is also deployed during the holiday season. Journeys take more than 6 hours. \$99.00 one way (weekend express), \$210.00 one way (vacation service).

By public transit

The public transit networks of surrounding suburbs and rural communities in surrounding counties run routes into Seattle, the transit hub of the entire region. They operate on more frequent schedules and are cheaper (or for free) for going further out than with Greyhound or Amtrak for the same distances:

- **Sound Transit Express buses (ST) (<https://www.soundtransit.org>)**, toll-free: +1-888-889-6368. Has regional public transit routes to suburbs in King County (e.g. Bellevue, Federal Way, Kent, Renton, Seattle), Snohomish County (e.g. Everett, Lynnwood) and Pierce County (e.g. Puyallup, Tacoma). Some routes operate daily throughout most of the day and some only operate Monday to Friday during the afternoon and evening rush hours. Routes operating in Seattle will include at least one stop at or near a Link light rail station. King County Metro operates Sound Transit Link Light Rail Routes 1 and 2, and Express bus routes 522, 542, 545, 550, 554, 556, 566 between Seattle (Downtown & U District) and the Eastside. Sound Transit operates only the Sounder N & S Line Trains and the Link Light Rail in Tacoma. (updated Feb 2025 |)
- **Community Transit (CT) (<https://www.communitytransit.org/>)** Operates local and regional public transit bus routes in Snohomish County, except only local routes in Everett.

Communities within the county served by this operator's routes include Arlington, Edmonds, Everett, Lynnwood, Marysville, Mill Creek, Monroe, Mountlake Terrace, Mukilteo, Snohomish, and Stanwood. From Downtown Seattle they operate express buses to Snohomish via Monroe & Woodinville (424). Other routes connect to the Link light rail 1 Line at Lynnwood, Shoreline North/185th Ave or Mountlake Terrace Stations. They operate Sound Transit routes 510, 512, 513, 515, 532, 535 from Seattle, Bellevue and Kirkland, to Lynnwood, Ash Way and Everett.

- **Everett Transit (<https://www.everetttransit.org>)** operates as local public transportation within the City of Everett from Everett Station and Seaway Transit Center. They serve the Mukilteo Ferry Terminal (18) and Paine Field Airport (8) from both Seaview Transit Center and Everett Station.
- **Island Transit (<https://www.islandtransit.org/routes-and-schedules>)** operates local bus routes within Island County (Whidbey Island and Camano Island). Nearest Island Transit stops from Camano Island are in Everett Station (412) and Stanwood (412, 411C & 3). The nearest Island Transit stop towards Seattle from Whidbey Island is at the Clinton Ferry Terminal (1, 58, 60).
- **Skagit Transit 90x (<https://www.skagittransit.org/90x/>)** ... continues from Everett Station to South Mt Vernon P&R, Mt Vernon Skagit Station, and Burlington. Passengers transfer to ST 510 to Downtown Seattle or 512 to Lynnwood and transfer to Link Light Rail to continue towards downtown Seattle via Shoreline, Northgate and University District. From Mt Vernon Skagit Station transfer to 80X to continue to Bellingham or 40x towards the San Juan Ferry Terminal via March's P&R.
- **Kitsap Transit (<https://www.kitsaptransit.com/service/fast-ferry>)** operates passenger-only catamaran ferries to Bremerton, Kingston, and Southworth from Pier 50 of the downtown waterfront. Washington State Ferries is still the only transport available for travel to Bainbridge Island. Passengers transfer to Kitsap Transit buses (<https://www.kitsaptransit.com/service/routed-buses>) from the ferry terminals in Kitsap County and to the following for going further into the Olympic Peninsula past Hood Canal:
 - **Jefferson Transit (<https://jeffersontransit.com/>)** connects Port Townsend to the Kingston Ferry Terminal (14) and the Bainbridge Island Ferry Terminal via Poulsbo (7 & 390) as the nearest stops to Downtown Seattle. Kitsap Transit #390 (<https://www.kitsaptransit.com/service/routed-buses/390-poulsbobainbridge>) connects the North Viking P&R to the Bainbridge Ferry terminal.
 - **Clallam Transit Strait Shot #123 (<https://www.clallamtransit.com/route123>)** provides a direct route between the Bainbridge Ferry Terminal and Port Angeles via Poulsbo, Discovery Bay, US-101 @ Jamestown, and Sequim. It is a two-hour bus ride from end to end. Check schedules. Connections to Jefferson Transit buses are at Poulsbo Viking Transit Center, Discovery Bay, and Sequim.
 - **Mason Transit #3 (<https://www.masontransit.org/busschedules/>)** Mason Transit's Route #3 connects the Bremerton Ferry Terminal to Belfair in Mason County. For going to Shelton transfer to Route 1 in Belfair.
- **Pierce Transit (PT) (<https://www.piercettransit.org/>)** Operates local and regional public transit bus routes in Pierce County. Communities within the county served by this operator's routes include Fife, Gig Harbor, Lakewood, Puyallup, Steilacoom, Tacoma. They operate Sound Transit routes 574, 577, 578, 586, 590, 592, 594, 595, 596 from Seattle or Seattle-Tacoma International Airport, to Tacoma, Lakewood, Auburn, Federal Way, Gig Harbor and Puyallup.
 - **Intercity Transit (<https://www.intercitytransit.com/plan-your-trip/routes>)** continues to Lacey (610) and Olympia (600 & 610) from SR-512 P&R and the Lakewood Sounder

Station in Lakewood. Passengers transfer to ST 592, 594 or Sounder S Line train for going to Downtown Seattle from Lakewood.

- **Greyhound Lines/Flixbus** (<https://www.greyhound.com>) operates local service along I-5 between Mount Vernon Skagit Station, Everett Station, Seattle (503 S Royal Brougham in SODO); Tacoma Dome, and downtown Olympia Transit Center. They are more expensive on a less frequent schedule but are quicker to travel across longer distances such as from Mount Vernon to Olympia or even from Olympia to Seattle. See **By bus** under **Get in** in the above.
- **Greyhound Connect** (<https://dungeness-line.com/>) operates the *Dungeness Line* between Port Angeles, Sequim, Discovery Bay, Port Townsend, Kingston, Edmonds, Seattle Greyhound Station (503 S Royal Brougham), and SeaTac. They go across Puget Sound on the Kingston-Edmonds Ferry. Additional stops are only on request at the VA Hospital, King Street Station, Swedish Hospital First Hill Campus, Arnold Pavilion, Poly Clinic, Virginia Mason and Harborview.

By boat

By ferry

Ferries are the primary mode for commuters living on the opposite sides of the Puget Sound from Tacoma/S Vashon Island (in the south) through Seattle/Kitsap Peninsula to Anacortes/San Juan Islands (in the north), since the sheer distance and the shipping traffic on the Sound make building a bridge difficult. For tourists, it's also a fantastic way to see some very picturesque views of the city and the surrounding country; be sure to bring a camera!



King County Metro Water Taxi



- **Washington State Ferries** (<https://wsdot.wa.gov/travel/washington-state-ferries>), ☎ +1 206-464-6400, toll-free: +1-800-843-3779. All Washington State Ferries carry vehicles, bicycles, and passengers. (updated Sep 2022 |)
 - **10 Colman Dock** (<https://www.wsdot.com/ferries/vesselwatch/terminaldetail.aspx?terminalid=7>), 801 Alaskan Way Pier 52 (*Pier 52*). Connects Downtown Seattle to Bainbridge Island and Bremerton on the Kitsap Peninsula.
 - **11 Fauntleroy Ferry Terminal** (<https://www.wsdot.com/ferries/vesselwatch/TerminalDetail.aspx?terminalid=9>), 4829 SW Barton St. Connects West Seattle to Vashon Island and Southworth on the Kitsap Peninsula.
- **12 King County Water Taxi** (<https://kingcounty.gov/depts/transportation/water-taxi.aspx>). Provides passenger and bicycle service from Pier 50 of Seattle's waterfront weekdays only during rush hour (5:30-8AM and 4:30-7PM) to Vashon Island, and all-day service (schedule is seasonally dependent) to West Seattle. \$5.50, \$4.75 if using ORCA.
- **13 Victoria Clipper** (<https://www.clippervacations.com>), 2701 Alaskan Way Pier 69 (*Alaskan Way & Clay St*), ☎ +1 206-448-5000, toll-free: +1-800-888-2535. High speed catamaran passenger ferries which connect Seattle to Victoria, British Columbia and the San Juan Islands. If you are heading to San Juan Islands, you can also join a whale-watching tour. About \$45 (one way), \$65 (round trip with advance reservation) to San Juan Islands; \$95 (single trip), \$120 (round trip with advance reservation) to Victoria. Fares vary slightly depending on season.

- **14 Kitsap Transit** (<https://www.kitsaptransit.com/service/fast-ferry>), 801 Alaskan Way Pier 50 (*Pier 50*), ☎ +1 206-464-6400, toll-free: +1-800-501 RIDE (7433). Passenger only fast ferries from Bremerton, Kingston and Southworth in catamaran vessels. Passengers connect to Kitsap Transit buses (<https://www.kitsaptransit.com/service/routed-buses>) from the ferry terminals in Bainbridge Island, Bremerton, Kingston and Southworth. (updated Sep 2022 |)

By cruise ship

Seattle is the main departure city for cruise ships heading towards Alaska or western Canada's fjords. Cruise ships to Seattle may be docked at one of two terminals in the Port of Seattle (<http://www.portseattle.org/maritime/cruise>)

- **15 Bell Street Pier Cruise Terminal at Pier 66** (<https://www.portseattle.org/places/bell-street-cruise-terminal-pier-66>), 2225 Alaskan Way S Pier 66, near the middle of Seattle's downtown waterfront. Serves as the home port for Norwegian Cruise Line and Celebrity Cruises. Has bus, taxi and shuttle connections for transfer of passengers and luggage. For travelers with connecting flights, Seattle-Tacoma International Airport is less than 15 mi (24 km) away.
- **16 Smith Cove Cruise Terminal at Pier 91** (<https://www.portseattle.org/maritime/terminal-91>), 2001 W Garfield St, at the north end of Seattle's downtown waterfront. Serves as home port to Holland America Line, Royal Caribbean and Princess Cruises. Other cruise lines may also use this terminal if the vessel is too large to use the Pier 66 terminal. King County Metro connects Pier 91 to downtown by the 19 and 24 buses.

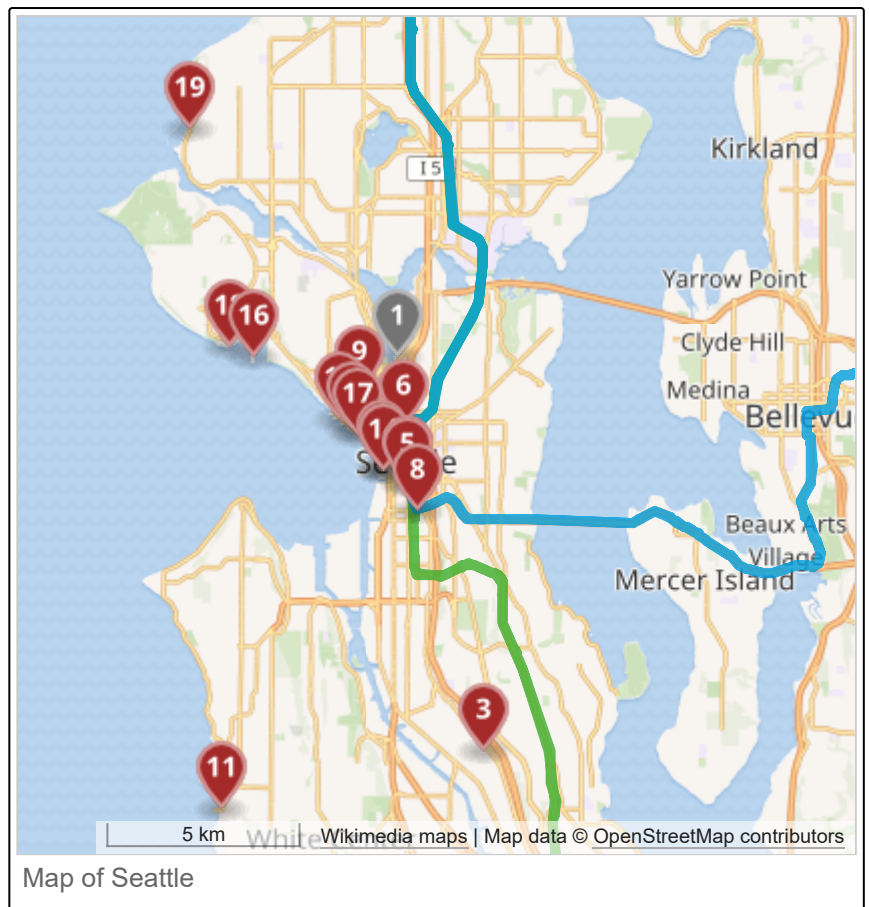
By private boat

Seattle has a variety of large marinas offering year-round guest moorage. The two marinas on the shores of Elliott Bay, **Elliott Bay Marina**, and **Bell Harbor Marina**, are the closest to Downtown. **Shilshole Bay Marina** is in the northern suburbs and is further away from most of the visitor attractions. There are numerous freshwater marinas on Lake Union, Portage Bay, and the Lake Washington Ship Canal, but these require passage through the Hiram M. Chittenden Locks. Visitors may also consider moorage in the neighboring cities of Edmonds, Everett, Des Moines, Kirkland, and Kingston.

- **17 Bell Harbor Marina** (<https://www.portseattle.org/maritime/shilshole-bay-marina>), 2203 Alaskan Way, ☎ +1-800-426-7817, bhm@portseattle.org (<mailto:bhm@portseattle.org>). Bell Harbor Marina, at the base of Bell Street in Downtown's Belltown neighborhood, is the closest marina to Downtown and is a comfortable walk to Pike Place Market, Westlake Center, the Seattle Aquarium, and other waterfront attractions. Reciprocal moorage is available year-round, and in the summer months, reservations are recommended. (updated Jul 2016 |)
- **18 Elliott Bay Marina** (<https://www.elliottbaymarina.co/>), 2601 West Marina Place, ☎ +1 206-285-4817, info@elliottbaymarina.net (<mailto:info@elliottbaymarina.net>). Elliott Bay Marina is a private marina on the north shore of Elliott Bay in the Magnolia neighborhood. This marina has expansive guest moorage and many premium services. A 10-minute walk from all-day bus service to Downtown Seattle. (updated Jul 2016 |)
- **19 Shilshole Bay Marina** (<https://www.portseattle.org/maritime/shilshole-bay-marina>), 7001 Seaview Ave. N.W., ☎ +1-800-426-7817, sbm@portseattle.org (<mailto:sbm@portseattle.org>). Shilshole Bay Marina is a gigantic marina in the Ballard neighborhood. It is a 20-30 minute drive to Downtown and is not served directly by public transportation. (updated Jul 2016 |)

Get around

Seattle's public transportation system, while no rival for Chicago or New York City, is the most convenient and simple way to get around most of the city. While public transportation is also good in suburbs such as Bothell and Everett, if you plan on visiting those areas you may wish to use a car. Driving a car in Seattle is possible, but the frequent and awful traffic congestion can leave you frustrated. Parking for free in Downtown and many of the adjacent neighborhoods, such as Capitol Hill, is all but impossible. Seattle is also one of the most bicycle-friendly cities in the country, although you should be aware of the hilly terrain of the city that often makes cycling difficult. Carsharing services such as Zipcar, and ridesharing services such as Lyft and Uber, are also convenient and safe transportation options.



Orientation

Seattle's street designations are generally easy to remember once you understand them. Most of the city is laid out in a grid, with north-south roads called **Avenues** and east-west roads being **Streets**. There are occasional irregularities: **Ways** are long roads that don't always conform to the grid, **Drives** are long, circuitous routes, and there's the occasional very short **Place** or **Court**.

Seattle has a somewhat convoluted address system that can be confusing to the uninitiated. Outside the downtown area, the city is divided into 7 compass directional sectors (N, NE, NW, W, E, S, SW; no SE section), with the name of the sector applied to every road that passes through that sector. Streets are written with the sector *before* the name (e.g. NE 45th Street or NE 45th) while avenues are written with the sector *after*

Helpful mnemonics to navigate Seattle

- **ST**reets run ea**ST** and we**ST**
- ave**NueS** run **N**orth and **S**outh
- **EveN** numbered addresses are on the **E**ast and **N**orth side of the road (which is likely called a *street* or *avenue*)
- Use the mnemonic "**J**esus **C**hrist **M**ade **S**eattle **U**nder **P**rotest" for downtown street names, from Yesler Way to Westlake Park. The streets are named as six first-letter pairs of these words (Jefferson & James, Cherry & Columbia, Marion & Madison, Spring & Seneca, University & Union, Pike & Pine))

the name (e.g. 45th Avenue NE or 45th NE). Roads within the downtown area (as well as some avenues east of Downtown and some streets north of Downtown) have no directional designation. Within a neighborhood, locals often omit the directionals when describing places, but mapping websites and apps require them, and may send you miles out of your way if you don't specify them. Take this into consideration when looking for directions to a specific address.

When locals give you directions, they may refer to an intersection (especially in the case of a bus stop). The first road mentioned is the street it is at, followed by the crossing street adjacent to the stop, but sometimes they neglect to specify whether it's an "avenue" or a "street," so inquire to be sure and you'll avoid the risk of winding up in the wrong part of the city!

On foot

Walking is highly encouraged for short trips, especially if your destination is within Downtown or Capitol Hill. While the streets and drivers are generally friendly for pedestrians, do keep your street smarts and avoid walking alone in the southern part of Downtown, International District, or the SoDo neighborhood at night. For more information about street safety, look at the "Stay Safe" section.

Seattle pedestrians are noted for their unusual **refusal to jaywalk**. Unlike many other large American cities (particularly those on the East Coast), in Seattle, you'll see groups of pedestrians patiently wait for the light to change before stepping off the curb, even when there isn't a car in sight. The reasons for it are unclear, though it's often suggested that the local police are particularly strict about enforcing the jaywalking law.

The block layout in the downtown area is pretty compact; a walk from Denny Way to Yesler Way should take roughly half an hour. Walking from the Waterfront towards I-5 in Downtown (particularly between Seneca St and Yesler Way) is steep and will leave you gasping for breath at every intersection! Outside the downtown area, especially Capitol Hill or the northern and western parts of the city, there are many hills (albeit less hilly and steep than San Francisco). In fact, walking is a great form of exercise in Seattle, with abundant jogging tracks in the parks and longer trails like the **Burke-Gilman Trail**, which runs along the northern side of the ship canal and the western rim of Lake Washington.

By public transit

ORCA Card

The **ORCA card** (<https://www.myorca.com/>) is a contactless fare card that enables you to ride and transfer seamlessly across most Puget Sound public transit agencies, including: King County Metro, Sound Transit, Community Transit, Everett Transit, Pierce Transit, Kitsap Transit, and Washington State Ferries. The card is \$3, and you must put in a minimum of \$5 in your **e-purse** to start using it. **Day passes** are available for \$8 and can be used for all bus and train services. Monthly passes are also available. You can request a refund of unused e-purse funds (<https://support.myorca.com/hc/en-us/articles/10285980987277-How-to-request-a-refund>).

You can purchase, add value to, or add a pass to an ORCA card at vending machines in many transit centers, inside all Link Light Rail and Sounder stations, at Metro's customer service centers, over the phone, and at many QFC and Safeway supermarkets. Youth and Senior ORCA cards can only be issued by mail or at Metro's main customer service center next to King Street Station in the International District and require proof of age (click [here \(https://www.myorca.com/\)](https://www.myorca.com/) for details). You can also acquire these cards in the mezzanine of Westlake Station — however, this customer service center is open only on the first and last 4 business days of the month.

There are no turnstiles at Link or Sounder stations. To pay the correct fare with an ORCA card when riding Sounder trains, **tap at the stations before you board**. There is no need to tap out. At a Link light rail station or major RapidRide bus stop, tap your ORCA card at a yellow fare reader before you board. On all other public transit — buses, streetcars, Washington State Ferries, and the Water Taxi — just tap when you board. ORCA includes free transfers for all modes except Washington State Ferries. For 2 hours after your first tap, you can use as many public transportation services as you like, other than ferries, and you only pay the highest fare once.

Effective February 23, 2026, ORCA card readers also accept tap to pay (<https://info.myorca.com/contactless/>) with contactless payment. Debit and credit cards with the near-field communications (NFC) logo printed on them, and devices compatible with NFC services like Apple Pay and Google Pay, are accepted, and provide free transfers within 2 hours. Card readers also recognize ORCA cards for Android and WearOS users who have purchased an ORCA card and loaded it into Google Wallet (<https://info.myorca.com/GooglePay/>). iOS and watchOS users can use credit and debit cards via Apple Pay, but not ORCA cards.

Electronic pass

Another alternative to buying transportation tickets is through the **Transit GO** (<https://kingcounty.gov/en/dept/metro/fares-and-payment/ways-to-pay/transit-go-ticket>) app. You may buy tickets using a debit or credit card on your phone, then activate a ticket only when you are about to use any public transportation mode within the city, except for Washington State Ferries. Transit GO tickets do not support transfers between modes or agencies, such as transferring from light rail to bus or vice versa. If you transfer modes at least twice, an ORCA card may save you money.

By light rail

Link light rail (<https://www.soundtransit.org/ride-with-us>). Sound Transit operates high-frequency rail transit in Seattle and its immediate suburbs. The lines are grade-separated, except in parts of South Seattle, which can cause the speed and reliability to vary. Adult fares are a flat \$3.00, regardless of distance; children 18 and under ride for free. Purchase your ticket at a machine, or on your phone using the Transit GO Ticket app, before you board, and keep it with you for the whole trip, as it may be randomly checked by personnel inside the train. If you use an ORCA card, you must **tap on** at your origin.

- **The 1 Line** (<https://www.soundtransit.org/ride-with-us/routes-schedules/1-line>) operates between Lynnwood City Center to the north and Federal Way Downtown to the south, stopping in Mountlake Terrace, Shoreline, Northgate, University of Washington/U District, Capitol Hill, Downtown, SoDo, South Seattle, Tukwila, and Sea-Tac Airport in SeaTac. It runs

every 6-15 minutes M-Sa from 5AM-1AM, Su from 6AM-midnight. (Overnight, Route 570 Night Bus (<https://www.soundtransit.org/ride-with-us/routes-schedules/570>) covers most of the same stops.)

- **The 2 Line** (<https://www.soundtransit.org/ride-with-us/routes-schedules/2-line>) connects Downtown Seattle to Downtown Redmond to the east via Bellevue, Mercer Island and Judkins Park, and from Downtown Seattle to Lynnwood City Center to the north with the same stops as the 1 Line.



Map of Link light rail stations within and near Seattle

By King County Metro

- **King County Metro** (<https://kingcounty.gov/en/dept/metro>), ☎ +1 206-553-3000. Operates bus, streetcar and monorail routes within King County. Serves Auburn, Bellevue, Bothell, Burien, Federal Way, Issaquah, Kent, Kirkland, Mercer Island, North Bend, Redmond, Renton, SeaTac, Seattle, Shoreline, Tukwila, Vashon Island, White Center, and Woodinville. \$3 for 2 hours (\$1 seniors 65+, Free youth 0-18). (updated Sep 2025 |)

Commonly referred to as **Metro**, it is the primary public transit operator serving Seattle, especially for local routes. The transportation system is easy to navigate, and most visitor attractions are served by frequent bus routes. Metro's buses are clean and comfortable and are driven by friendly and skilled operators. Most buses, especially on routes in the Center City, are brand-new and air-conditioned — perfect on one of Seattle's hot summer days. The agency provides several types of routes:



King County Metro Bus

- **Local bus service** constitutes the majority of bus routes and are operated by green, blue, or purple buses. These buses are identified by route numbers between 1 and 399.
- **RapidRide** is an express Bus Rapid Transit service with modern, 3-door, red and yellow buses. RapidRide buses are an efficient way to get to many outlying neighborhoods and are identified by **route letters**.
- The **Seattle Streetcar** (<https://www.seattle.gov/transportation/getting-around/transit/streetcar>) has two lines: The **South Lake Union** line between Downtown and South Lake Union and the **First Hill** line between Pioneer Square, the International District and Capitol Hill along Broadway. The former line gained the rather unfortunate moniker "SLUT" (South Lake Union Trolley), and you might hear it referred to as such. The streetcar runs up to every 10 minutes and costs \$2.25 per adult and \$1 per senior, regardless of distance. Youth board for free. You must purchase a ticket or tap your ORCA card at one of the streetcar stops before boarding. Note that these streetcars stop only when requested by pressing the yellow stop request strip.
- The **Seattle Center Monorail** (<https://www.seattlemonorail.com/>), a legacy of the 1962 World's Fair, takes you non-stop between Westlake Center (5th Avenue & Pine Street) and the Seattle Center in just 2 minutes, and primarily serves tourists heading from Downtown to the Space Needle. One-way tickets are \$3.50 per adult, \$1.75 children ages 6-18/seniors.



RapidRide Bus Rapid Transit with limited stops

Buses within Seattle generally operate from 5AM to Midnight and run at least every 30 minutes, with frequent service and RapidRide buses arriving every 5-15 minutes at rush hour. If you are planning on traveling before 6AM or after 9PM be sure to make use of the excellent **Trip Planner** (<https://kingcounty.gov/depts/transportation/metro/trip-planner/info.aspx>) to make sure you can get to your destination.

Almost all frequent service buses traveling through Downtown have stops along 3rd Ave, with virtually every Downtown bus having a stop near the intersection of 3rd & Pine/Pike. Other routes have southbound stops along 2nd Ave and northbound along 4th and 5th Ave.

The adult bus **fare** is \$3 at all times and on all routes. The senior (ages 65 or older) fare is \$1. Youth (18 and under) ride free. If you pay by cash (exact change only), you'll get a paper transfer good for within a 2-hour period to ride other King County Metro buses. An ORCA card allows you to transfer to other transit agencies within the same period of time for free. Note that you'll only need to tap in when you enter the bus, although in RapidRide, you can tap on the reader before getting on the bus and may board from the center and rear doors.

To figure out how to get to your destination use the excellent **Trip Planner** (<https://kingcounty.gov/depts/transportation/metro/trip-planner/info.aspx>) which gives you point-to-point directions between points within King County. For **real-time arrival times**, use the **One Bus Away** (<https://onebusaway.org/>) or **Transit** (<https://transitapp.com/>) app. Google Maps and Apple Maps also include real-time public transportation data for route planning.

When traveling to destinations outside the downtown core, make sure to ask the drivers about the green and white "EXPRESS" signs in their windows or the "VIA EXPRESS" on the road display if they are going to your destination. Some of these express routes are intended for regular commuters traveling between residential neighborhoods and Downtown and make few or no stops between, but may be useful to some visitors.

When in doubt, ask the bus driver or a security guard before boarding. Most employees are knowledgeable about the transportation system (or at least the route they are driving) and will be able to help you. Additionally, all buses are fully accessible for wheelchairs and walkers.

By water taxi

The **Water Taxi** (<https://kingcounty.gov/depts/transportation/metro/travel-options/water-taxi.aspx>) travels between Pier 50 (at the foot of Yesler Way) and Seacrest Park in West Seattle. The scenic ride takes 15 minutes and costs \$4.75 (one way, exact change only), or \$4 with an ORCA Card. Boats depart every half-hour on weekdays and every hour on weekends during the summer months, with reduced service during the winter.

By car

Cars are not typically the best option for transportation within the city proper, especially in Downtown, Capitol Hill and Queen Anne. Many streets are one-way, and a few are restricted to buses. Additionally, driving in Seattle often requires braking and accelerating on steep hills. Inland waterways cause choke points around the

Eyes on the road at all times!
Do NOT use, hold, or look at your phone while driving, even while stopped in a red light! Police across the Washington State are also on

few available bridges. All this causes Seattle's traffic congestion to consistently rank among the worst in the U.S.

Cars are more useful for traveling to outer neighborhoods, and suburbs such as Bellevue, Redmond, Everett, and Tacoma. Drivers traveling on I-5 between Downtown and Northgate can use the express lanes for a generally quick and smooth ride to downtown in the morning, or to the suburbs in the afternoon and evening.

If you only need a car for part of your trip, traditional car rental companies like Avis and Hertz have locations in the city; compared with the airport, these are often cheaper, but hours and vehicle availability are more limited at city locations. Turo (<https://turo.com/>) and Getaround (<https://getaround.com/>) let you rent vehicles by the hour or by the day from private owners, including many in residential neighborhoods. **Zipcar** (<https://www.zipcar.com/seattle>) rents vehicles by the half-hour, and requires a paid membership; if you have a Zipcar membership in another city, it should work in Seattle as well. Read your rental provider's terms and fee schedules carefully, and follow their rules when you end a rental, to avoid getting any surprise charges.

the lookout for unsafe driving because of distractions, including eating, drinking, smoking, and grooming. The fine for the first offence is \$136. The law applies for all gadgets, big or small, and "driving" includes times when you are not moving.

If you need to use your phone or GPS for navigation, input your destination *before* driving or have a passenger do it for you. Should there be a need to answer or make phone calls, use speakerphone or a hands-free device, including your car's entertainment system. Postpone writing texts or e-mails until you are safely parked. Use your phone's voice assistant feature if you need to.

In less dense neighborhoods, many establishments provide free short-term parking for customers. In Downtown and other popular areas, free parking might only be available on Sundays and holidays, and you should allow at least 20 minutes to find a space and then walk from it to your destination. Hotels often charge exorbitant fees for overnight parking. Street parking is \$1 to \$3.00 per hour (debit cards and credit cards other than Discover accepted), while a parking ticket can be in excess of \$35 for going overtime in a 2-hour zone. Read the instructions on parking meters carefully to understand whether you need to display a sticker or receipt on your car.

When **parking on a hill**, always **apply the parking brake** and **turn your wheels** so that the car will roll into the sidewalk instead of the street if the brakes give out. When facing uphill, turn toward the street; when facing downhill, turn toward the curb.

By taxi

You can call or hail a taxi from any major street in Seattle or most hotels will call them for you. However, most of Seattle's taxi services are unfriendly and expensive, especially if you are only trying to get around the downtown area. Some taxi drivers will even refuse to take you if your destination is less than 15 blocks away. The fares are regulated by the city government:

- Flagfall for \$2.60
- \$0.30 for each additional 1/9 mile (a total of \$2.70 per mile)

- \$0.30 for every 36 seconds of waiting time (a total of \$0.50 per minute)
- \$0.50 for each additional passenger above 18 after two.

If you are heading to SEA Airport from the downtown area, a flat fare of \$40 is applied.

Bring cash if you intend to take a taxi; drivers can make change. If you don't have enough (or any) cash, ask the driver *before your ride begins* whether they accept cards. Seattle taxi drivers are notorious for telling passengers that they will take a card, then claiming that their payment card reader is somehow unavailable at the end of a ride, even offering to drive passengers to an ATM to get cash. You may need to ask multiple times to use your card if you have no cash.

The user-unfriendliness of taxi companies has driven many customers to **ride-hailing** alternatives (see the following section). Should you be in dire need of a taxi, you can hail one on the street, typically in and near Downtown, or you can call one of these companies:

- **Yellow Cab** (<https://seattleyellowcab.com/>), ☎ +1 206-622-6500.
- **Orange Cab** (<http://www.orangecab.net>), ☎ +1 206-522-8800, +1 206-957-0866.
- **Stita Taxi Services** (<https://www.stitataxi.com/>), ☎ +1 206-246-9999.

By ride-hailing service

If your destination is miles away and you don't have a car, yet public transportation seems inconvenient for you, you can use ride-hailing services like those provided by **Uber** (<https://www.uber.com/cities/seattle>) or **Lyft** (<https://www.lyft.com>). As of 2024, Uber and Lyft often cost more than taxis, but especially outside of Downtown, they provide generally fast and reliable service, with a range of vehicle options.

By motorcycle

The rainy weather makes motorcycling difficult but not impossible. Drivers exhibit an alarming obliviousness to motorcycles, and riders should take care to stay well out of a car's blind spot and preferably ahead of, rather than behind, any car. Motorcyclists get preferred boarding on the ferries and there are many parking spots Downtown reserved for motorcycles.

By bicycle

Cycling is better in Seattle than in most American cities. In fact, **during rush hour, it's often faster to bike than to drive!** Bicycle commuting has been embraced by Seattle, and drivers are a little more accustomed to bicycles than in other major cities. Your main drawbacks will be the wet roads, the rain, and the hilly terrain, so you might want to pack some raingear. Many major roads have properly maintained bicycle lanes, and you are allowed to ride bicycles on all Seattle roads except the Interstates. Helmets are not required — a law mandating them was repealed in 2022 — but are commonly worn by riders. Electric motor-assisted bikes, or **e-bikes**, make the hills much easier to traverse, and are widely available for rent in the city.

Public transit is very friendly towards bikes. King County Metro buses have bike racks on the front of the bus; tell the driver you want to mount or dismount your bike. Light rail and streetcars have bike racks towards the center of every car, or you can hold your bike upright if

those are full. Ferries welcome bicycles with priority loading and unloading; there is a \$1 bicycle surcharge above the passenger fare, but it's waived if you pay with an ORCA card.

The city maintains a **bike map** (<https://www.seattle.gov/transportation/projects-and-programs/programs/bike-program/bike-web-map>) with suggested routes for visiting major attractions. Popular routes include:

- The **I-90 and WA-520 bridges** over Lake Washington have bike paths running parallel to the vehicle lanes.
- The **Burke-Gilman Trail** (<https://kingcounty.gov/services/parks-recreation/parks/trails/regional-trails/popular-trails/burke-gilman.aspx>) is a paved walking/jogging/cycling trail that winds its way from the north end of Lake Washington, down around the University of Washington, then west along the ship canal towards Ballard. The trail is on an old railroad right-of-way, so it maintains a very consistent elevation and is excellent for commuting or a casual day's touring.
- The **Elliott Bay Trail** overlooks Puget Sound and starts at the north end of Downtown in Myrtle Edwards Park, continuing north along the shore of Elliott Bay. It has gorgeous views of the Olympics and Mt. Rainier, and does not intersect any roads.

Seattle has a **dockless e-bike and scooter share** program operated by Lime. Vehicles are parked wherever the last user stopped or wherever a professional "juicer" just dropped off a freshly-charged batch, usually at bike racks, near popular attractions, or at large street corners. You use the Lime or Uber app on your smartphone to locate and unlock bikes; when you're done, park the bike and end the rental in the app. One user can start a group ride for up to 5 vehicles at a time. **Helmets are not provided**, so if you want to wear one, you'll have to bring your own or buy one at a local shop.

- **Lime** (<https://www.li.me/locations>). Green Lime e-bikes and scooters rented using the Lime or Uber app. \$1 to start, \$0.48/minute; prepaid discount passes available. (updated Jul 2024 |)

See

*Individual listings can be found in
Seattle's [district articles](#)*

Seattle has a lot to see, be it prominent sights or attractions tucked away in quiet neighborhoods. For more information, look at each district's individual articles.

- **Seattle CityPASS** (<https://www.citypass.com/seattle>). A discount pass that includes admission to five attractions for half the normal fee combined. You are entitled to up to two visits (within 24 hours) to the **Space Needle** and a visit to the **Seattle Aquarium**. You also get three choices of an **Argosy Cruises Harbor Tour**, admission to the **Museum of Pop Culture**, the **Woodland Park Zoo**, the **Pacific Science Center** the **Museum of Flight**, or **Chihuly Garden & Glass**. A CityPASS is valid for 9 consecutive days starting with the use of your first ticket.



Pike Place Market



Transportation and parking are not included. \$127 for adult, \$97 for children (ages 5-12), plus tax and a \$2 processing fee per ticket. (updated Jul 2024 |)

Landmarks

The first thing that pops into most people's minds when they think of Seattle is the **Space Needle**, north of Downtown in the Seattle Center. Although it's not the tallest building in Seattle, it still has a wonderful 360-degree view of both the city and the surrounding landscape. It is best to visit at sunset, when the mountains and sky will be lit up in beautiful colors. For a cheaper and less crowded option, head to the observatory at the **Columbia Center** building, which is higher than the Space Needle! For a better view of the waterfront and the downtown area, go aboard the **Seattle Great Wheel**.

Downtown, the **Pike Place Market** is Seattle's largest tourist area. Home to the famous fish market, the original Starbucks Coffee shop, produce stands, and a dedicated lane each for florists and foods. Don't forget to visit **Post Alley**, just a block away from Pike Place as you walk away from the shore, as there are some excellent food and souvenir places tucked away.

Museums

Seattle has a number of top-notch museums. Downtown is home to the renowned **Seattle Art Museum** (SAM), which displays a good assortment of art from around the world. On Capitol Hill, the **Seattle Asian Art Museum** is part of SAM and focuses mainly on Chinese and Japanese Art, but includes works from as far away as India. SAM also operates the large waterfront **Olympic Sculpture Garden** near the north end of Downtown, which has free admission. Additionally, **The Wing Luke Museum of the Asian Pacific American Experience** in the International District is the only Asian Pacific American museum in the nation (as against a museum of a specific Asian nationality). On First Hill, just east of Downtown, is the **Frye Art Museum**, a small private collection featuring 232 paintings, including numerous works from the so-called Munich Secession; the Frye often has excellent temporary exhibits, and offers free admission.



The Museum of Pop Culture beneath the Space Needle

Surrounding the Space Needle on the grounds of the Seattle Center are several more big museums, including the **Pacific Science Center**, an interactive science museum with an IMAX theater and plenty of science displays, the **Museum of Pop Culture**, a museum celebrating popular film, television, music, and other media, with exhibits on Seattle's vibrant music scene, and the **Chihuly Garden & Glass**, which takes glass art to the next level. Nearby South Lake Union is home to both the **Museum of History and Industry** and the **Center for Wooden Boats**, the latter offering free admission.

On the waterfront in Downtown is the popular **Seattle Aquarium**. The University District holds the **Henry Art Gallery**, one of the biggest contemporary art museums in Washington, and the **Burke Museum**, a combination natural history/archaeology museum. Ballard, about 7 miles northwest of Downtown, features the **National Nordic Museum**. To the south, just past Georgetown, is the **Museum of Flight**, with a large collection of aircraft ranging from wood and fabric crates to the sleek Concorde, and home to the first U.S. presidential jet.

Architecture

Most of the architectural attractions in Seattle are in the downtown area, easily traversed on foot. Among the highlights are the **Central Library**, a unique contemporary building, designed by Rem Koolhaas, with an enormous glass-fronted atrium; the **Columbia Center**, the tallest building in the Pacific Northwest and which offers excellent views from its observation deck; and the **Seattle City Hall** with its roof garden. On the south side of Downtown, near Pioneer Square, is the **Smith Tower**, an Art Deco building which was the tallest building west of the Mississippi from its completion in 1914 until 1931, and which has an observation deck. On the north side of Downtown, the **Amazon Spheres** draw gawkers. Just north of Downtown in Seattle Center, the **Museum of Pop Culture**, designed to resemble Jimi Hendrix's smashed guitar, is done in a manner only Frank Gehry could conceive; nearby is the **Gates Foundation Campus**, with its 12-acre garden.



Seattle's Downtown from the Space Needle

Of course, the most popular view in Seattle remains the one from the revolving top of the **Space Needle** at the Seattle Center. And given the retro-futurism look of the Space Needle, a fitting way to get there is via the **Monorail**, which connects the Seattle Center to Downtown. Another excellent view is from the **Seattle Great Wheel** at Pier 57, a Ferris wheel that offers superb views of the skyline and the waterfront.

While Seattle's residential architecture rarely strives for drama, you could also easily spend hours walking some of the city's older residential districts (often as notable for the gardens as for the houses). One of the best possibilities, and not too far from Downtown, is **Capitol Hill**, with a wide variety of houses and apartment buildings east of Broadway, some grand mansions north of Mercer Street and Seattle University's Chapel of St. Ignatius.



The Chapel of St. Ignatius: "seven bottles of light in a stone box"

Parks and outdoors

Seattle is peppered with parks, from small urban squares to large forested areas, many with breathtaking views of the city skyline, Puget Sound and surrounding mountains. Seattle's original park system was designed in the early 1900s by the Olmsted Brothers, the famous landscape architects behind many of America's most iconic urban parks. While many other American cities have only one or two Olmsted-designed parks, Seattle has over a dozen. Urban planners celebrate Seattle's park system as one of the best designed and best preserved in the United States.

Seattle Center is actually a park itself, with attractions besides the Space Needle and the center's numerous museums. The Kobe Bell and the mural beside it and the International Fountain are often overlooked but should not be missed. Up on Queen Anne Hill is **Kerry Park**, where you'll be spellbound by the most photographed view of Seattle. To the west is **Discovery Park**, the city's largest park with trails less traveled traversing hills and offering a view of the unspoiled landscape, wildlife, and a lighthouse.



South Lake Union and downtown
Seattle as seen from South Lake Union
Park

Overlooking Lake Union in Fremont is **Gasworks Park**.

Once the site of a coal gasification plant, the plant has been replaced by lush green hills surrounding one small section of rusting—yet surprisingly picturesque—machinery from the coal plant. The park is filled with spectators for the 4th of July fireworks and is also a great place for boaters to access Lake Union. For a day at the beach, head over to **Golden Gardens Park** or the less crowded **Carkeek Park** for a view of Puget Sound and the Olympic Mountains; West Seattle's fully sandy **Alki Beach** offers a great view of Downtown Seattle, as does the unusual **Jack Block Park** on Port land in the industrial part of West Seattle along Elliott Bay. Joggers can spend their time at **Green Lake Park** or **Magnuson Park** for a serene view of water by the running tracks.

A place to see trees from around the world is at the **Washington Park Arboretum** in the Central District. The Arboretum contains a **Japanese Garden** (closed in winter) that plays host to a traditional Japanese festival. For a more laid back and Zen atmosphere, the **Kubota Garden** at Rainier Beach in south Seattle has streams and waterfalls, ponds, rock outcroppings, and an exceptionally rich and mature collection of plants. If you are into animals, head to the **Woodland Park Zoo** to see animals from around the world held in pleasant, naturalistic exhibits.

Do

Individual listings can be found in Seattle's district articles

Tours

- **Kenmore Air** (<https://kenmoreair.com>), 950 Westlake Ave N, ☎ +1-866-435-9524. 20 minute plane tours over Seattle that are narrated by the pilot, with spectacular views of the

city. Tours begin and end at the west side of Lake Union. Reservations required. \$99.50 per person.

- Pioneer Square has a variety of tours of the **Seattle Underground**, the below-street-level corridors that were created when the district was raised by one floor during rebuilding after a massive fire in 1889. These informative tours are a great way to learn about Seattle's early history.

Water tours and cruises

- **Argosy Cruises** (<https://www.argosycruises.com/>), 1101 Alaskan Way, Pier 55. Cruise schedule varies by season. Ticket booth: Daily 10AM-4:05PM. Boat tour company with special dinner and sightseeing cruises. The most common tour is the hour-long **Harbor Cruise** on Elliott Bay, which offers excellent views of the Space Needle, Downtown skyline, freight harbor, and usually some sea lions, with a barrage of informative commentary about local history or interesting ships or cargo passing through that day. The **Locks Cruise** is a 2-hour one-way trip (in alternating directions) through the locks separating Elliot Bay and Lake Union, with an optional bus ride if you prefer a round trip. Seasonal cruises include the **Summer Views Cruise** with a sunset on Puget Sound, and **Husky Football Cruises** on Lake Washington before the games. Most cruises offer a decent full-service bar with large drinks and some snacks. Harbor cruise \$30.50. Locks cruise \$42.50, bus connection \$5 additional. Discounts for kids 4-12 and seniors. (updated Mar 2018 |)
- **1 Waterways Cruises** (<https://www.waterwayscruises.com/>), 901 Fairview Ave N Suite A100, ☎ +1 206-223 2060. Cruises on Sa-Su and sometimes F; see schedule online. Office: M-F 9AM-5PM. Luxury dining cruises touring Lake Union and Lake Washington. Regular cruises include 2-hour weekend brunch and Sunday supper buffets, and a 2½-hour four-course dinner (business casual attire). Brunch \$65, Sunday supper \$60, dinner \$85. (updated Feb 2018 |)

There are a number of smaller operations offering private charter cruises, for more niche interests like old steamer ships, sailboats, or just a more personal experience with a friendly captain-and-bartender. These are best searched for online.

The **ferries** are a cheaper way to experience a boat ride. The 35-minute trip to Bainbridge Island, with its quaint harbor village, is scenic and easy to board from downtown. See § Ferries under Go next.

Water sports

Seattle is surrounded by Lake Washington and Puget Sound, and there are a number of bodies of water within the city proper, such as Lake Union or Green Lake. Activities from kayaking to swimming are popular, especially in the summer.

Alki Beach in West Seattle is the recreation hub for Elliott Bay and the Puget Sound, with sea kayak rentals and tours available. If you'd rather get out on Lake Union, tour and rental agencies operate out of South Lake Union and the University District, offering sailing lessons and even free weekly cruising. Be aware that Lake Union is busy with commercial traffic and seaplane landings. Green Lake Park offers calm waters for paddling and swimming.

Events

Most of Seattle's festivals take place in the summer, the only season when Seattle has reliably sunny weather.

- **Chinese Lunar New Year (<https://www.seattlechinatownid.com/experiences/lunar-new-year>)** (*International District*). Jan/Feb. Numerous stalls and performances, and don't forget to partake in all the cheap food!

- **Seattle International Film Festival (<https://www.siff.net/>)** (SIFF) (*Downtown, Seattle Center, Uptown*), ☎ +1 206 464-5830, info@siff.net (<mailto:info@siff.net>). May. One of the largest film festivals in North America, showing international cinema. Watch indie films at Seattle area screens and vote for your favorite; each category winner receives a Golden Space Needle trophy. SIFF also screens films year-round at its venues.

- **Northwest Folklife Festival (<https://nwfolklife.org/>)**, 305 Harrison St (*Seattle Center*), ☎ +1-206-684-7300, folklife@nwfolklife.org (<mailto:folklife@nwfolklife.org>). Memorial Day weekend. A more low-key and local version of Bumbershoot, mainly family-friendly. Free (\$10 donation per person per day encouraged). (updated Jan 2026 |)

- **Fremont Fair (<https://fremontfair.com/>)** (*Fremont*). a weekend in mid or late June. Home of the Solstice Parade (including the nude bike ride), and a really fun drunken time all over Fremont. Vendors, bad live music and eclectic crowds at the bars make for an interesting time. Friends who live in Fremont become especially valuable for a place to crash during the fair.

- **Seattle PrideFest (<https://www.seattlepridefest.org/>)** (*Seattle Center*). A weekend in June or July. One of the biggest gay pride festivals in the country. Food carts, beer gardens, adult theme performances, and the eagerly anticipated Pride Parade.

- **Bite of Seattle (<https://www.biteofseattle.com/>)** (*Seattle Center*). mid/late July. Part of Seafair festivities. Enjoy some of the best delicacies of Seattle.

- **Capitol Hill Block Party (<https://www.capitolhillblockparty.com/>)** (*Capitol Hill*). a mid-summer weekend. Yearly live music event held on Capitol Hill over a weekend in mid-summer (usually the end of July). Consists primarily of local independent bands of various styles, coupled with some bigger name independent label acts.

- **Seafair (<https://www.seafair.org/>)** (*everywhere*). July-early August. Seattle's biggest festival, signifying the arrival of summer. Neighborhood events such as parades and street fairs run throughout the festival, with the downtown Torchlight Parade in late July. Seafair culminates in early August when hydroplane races and the Blue Angels bring loud, fast boats and planes to Lake Washington.
- **Bumbershoot (<https://eagle-pumpkin-tcx5.squarespace.com/>)** (*Seattle Center*). Labor Day weekend (early September). Seattle's largest music and arts festival, featuring dozens of local and world-class musical acts.



Sailboat moored at the Center for Wooden Boats



SIFF 2025 at its Uptown Theater



In costume for the Fremont Fair

- **Night Market & Autumn Moon Festival** (<https://www.seattlechinatownid.com/experiences/c-id-night-market>) (*International District*). Early September. Chinese festival of food and outdoor market.
- **Luminata** (<https://fremontartscouncil.org/luminata>) (*Green Lake*). Evening of the autumnal equinox. A festival of lights at Green Lake, including a procession from the old Aqua Theatre to a clearing about 3/4 mile north.

Seattle Center hosts smaller events almost every weekend throughout the year.

- **Festál Cultural Center** (<https://seattlecenter.com/events/featured-events/festal>) (*Seattle Center*). Year-round except December. Celebrate the world with festivals from about 25 countries represented, one country nearly every 2 weeks.

There are dozens of neighborhood street fairs, most of them on weekends between mid-May and late July, with a few in August, September, or even early October. These range from a classic car show in Greenwood to a seafood festival in Ballard; nearly all feature a vast array of food trucks and booths, and some (especially those in Ballard, West Seattle, and Georgetown) often have genuinely first-rate music, especially toward evening.

A few churches and other religious congregations host festivals that also draw many thousands of people, the two biggest probably being Bon Odori at the Seattle Buddhist Church just west of the International District, and St. Demetrios Greek Orthodox Church in otherwise sleepy Montlake, which hosts its festival in late September or early October, far enough into the autumn (and the rainier weather) that they do a good portion of it under a giant marquee tent. Check local listings for exact dates.

Sports

Of the four biggest U.S. professional leagues, three have teams in Seattle, and the fast-growing Major League Soccer also has a Seattle team.

The local National Football League franchise, the **Seattle Seahawks**, packs Lumen Field to the gills with the "12th man" (the name for loud, devout Seahawks fans) watching their home game in late summer through early winter. Soccer fans can enjoy **Seattle Sounders FC** games from late February through October, also held at Lumen Field. T-Mobile Park next door is home to the Major League Baseball **Seattle Mariners**. The



Seafair Indian Days Pow Wow at Daybreak Star Cultural Center



Luminata



It's always crowded and loud at Lumen Field!

city's latest sports offering, which started play in 2021, is the NHL's **Seattle Kraken**, who play at the Climate Pledge Arena (the renovated KeyArena at Seattle Center).

Seattle has one of the strongest followings for women's teams in sports. The **Seattle Storm** play basketball in the WNBA, and share Climate Pledge Arena with the Kraken. **Seattle Reign FC**, playing in the top level of US women's soccer, the National Women's Soccer League, returned to Seattle in 2022 after three seasons in Tacoma; it shares Lumen Field with the Seahawks and Sounders. In minor league men's sports, the **Seattle Thunderbirds** junior hockey team (players age 16 to 20) plays in Kent.

College teams also have a proud presence in town. The aforementioned **Washington Huskies** play basketball and football at their own venues on the University of Washington campus. The rivalry between "U-Dub" (short name for the campus) and "Wazzu" (the Washington State University Cougars, from Pullman) flares up every fall. Before the 2024 collapse of the Pac-12 Conference, the teams had played in October or November; future games will be played in mid-September. The 2024 game was played at Lumen Field, and will return to Husky Stadium every even-numbered year after that. Seattle University has the **Seattle Redhawks**, another NCAA Division I team, but with a much lower profile than U-Dub (especially since the Redhawks don't have a football team).

Entertainment

The major sports stadiums - **Lumen Field** and **T-Mobile Park** in SoDo, and **Climate Pledge Arena** at Seattle Center - frequently host big concerts by world famous artists. Other large performance venues include **Paramount Theatre** and **Moore Theatre**, both Downtown.

Benaroya Hall, in Downtown, is the home of the Seattle Symphony and is a frequent host of fine arts performances. The nearby **5th Avenue Theatre** is the main venue for Broadway musical shows. **McCaw Hall**, the home of the Seattle Opera and the Pacific Northwest Ballet, is in Seattle Center, along with several smaller venues.

Stand-up and improv comedy can be found Downtown, in Pioneer Square, on Capitol Hill, or in the University District.

Learn

Given the huge influx of people to Seattle, educational institutions have been constantly adding programs to the point that they now cover virtually every occupation. These are the largest universities:

- **University of Washington (<https://www.washington.edu/>)** main campus is in the University District. It's one of the largest schools in the country, and the biggest employer in Seattle proper. It's known for its computer science, biology, business, engineering, and medicine programs. Even if you're not studying here, the campus is worth a visit to admire its neo-Gothic architecture or the pink cherry blossom trees at the Quad in early spring.
- **Seattle University (<https://www.seattleu.edu/>)** is a private Jesuit (Catholic) university at Capitol Hill and the second-largest university in the area. SU is famous for its community service and non-profit sponsored projects.

- **Seattle Pacific University** (<https://spu.edu/>) on Queen Anne Hill is Free Methodist affiliated and offers liberal arts programs, as well as science and professional certifications.
- **City University of Seattle** (<https://cityu.edu/>) is notable for its management and graduate programs.
- **Bastyr University** (<https://bastyr.edu/>) in Kenmore, just outside Seattle, is well known for its healthcare and natural therapy programs. It was founded by Dr. John Bastyr, a longtime local expert in naturopathic, homeopathic, and chiropractic.



The Quad at University of Washington



Community colleges often offer some fun short-term courses.

North Seattle College (<https://northseattle.edu/>) has the most diverse selection, with a focus on machinery, ventilation, and even wristwatch making. Other colleges within the same system are **Seattle Central College** (<https://seattlecentral.edu/>) and **South Seattle College** (<https://southseattle.edu/>). If you want to get out of the crowded city, you can also choose **Green River** (<https://www.greenriver.edu/>) to the south, as well as **Shoreline** (<https://www.shoreline.edu/>) and **Edmonds** (<https://www.edmonds.edu/>) to the north.

Work

Seattle is a well-known center for business, with the headquarters of tech companies Amazon and Microsoft, coffee chain Starbucks, retail and grocery stores such as Nordstrom, REI and Costco in the city and its surrounding area. While aircraft manufacturer Boeing now has its overall headquarters in Arlington, Virginia, it maintains its divisional headquarters for its commercial aircraft and financing operations in the Seattle area, also home to two of its largest factories. There's plenty of startup companies, many of which are tech-based startups pushed out of the exorbitantly expensive Silicon Valley. While you can't expect similar wages or work environment to the large companies, many do offer perks such as free haircut, lunch, apartment rent with one or more working partners, or carpool service.

Health is another growing sector of the economy. Seattle is one of the fittest cities in the nation and nutritionists, doctors, and nurses are in need to take care of the growing population. Biotech companies are also on the rise. Comparatively, the hospitality business has been growing at a glacial pace compared to the tech moguls.

One good reason to work in Seattle, or the rest of Washington state for that matter, is that there is no state income tax.

Seattle has one of the highest minimum wages in the U.S., and under Washington state law any tips are strictly *in addition to* minimum wage, but housing prices are high, so there is still quite a squeeze on low-end wage-earners. If you can work out your living situation, it's relatively easy to get a food service job in Seattle (and, in particular, it would appear that good espresso baristas are *always* in demand).

Buy

Individual listings can be found in Seattle's [district articles](#)

If you want it, you can most likely get it in Seattle. Residents joke about "shopping local" or "supporting local business" at Amazon, Costco, and Starbucks, headquartered in or near the city. Despite the presence of these corporate giants (or as a reaction to them), Seattleites take pride in the many small, locally-owned businesses also operating here. Major chains and box stores do not tend to thrive in the city or its inner suburbs (with the notable exception of Starbucks, which has eighty-nine locations in the city).

A sales tax of 10.25% applies for most purchases, except for groceries, newspapers, and prescription drugs, which are tax-free. Purchases of hard liquor, soft drinks, cannabis, rental cars, and hotel rooms are subject to higher taxes.

Downtown

- The **Pike Place Market**, Seattle's most popular attraction, is well-known for its seafood and produce stands. At the main entrance to the market is Pike Place Fish, famous for its handlers who throw fish to each other, but there are plenty of other seafood stands as well. In the main market complex are several levels of restaurants and shops selling antiques, arts and crafts, and souvenirs, and as the weather gets warmer, artisans sell their wares in the upper open-air level as well. Although it is flush with tourists, especially in the summer months, area residents and Downtown workers regularly shop at the market as well, which minimizes the "tourist trap" feel. It is also believed by many that the lower floors of the market are haunted.
- The **Westlake** retail corridors on Pike, Pine, and Union Street between 3rd and 7th Avenues are also a great place to shop, with stores by big fashion and activewear brands.
- **Belltown**, just north of the downtown area, has a plethora of designer art galleries, fashion, and accessory workshops.
- **Pioneer Square**, just south of downtown, is the cheaper counterpart to Belltown, with more eclectic accessories.



Abundant seafood at Pike Place Market

Other districts

- **Ballard**: Most shopping options here are on Ballard Avenue NW between 20th & 22nd Avenue NW. If big brands don't interest you, head here for stylish urban and hip fashion.
- **Capitol Hill**: Most shops here are in the western part of the neighborhood near I-5 (E Pike & Pine Street, Broadway and Melrose Ave), where the streets are filled with mid-range fashion options and a little bit of everything, befitting the hippest district of Seattle. Here you'll also find two of Seattle's most well-known bookstores, the sprawling Elliott Bay Book Company and used bookstore/cat sanctuary Twice Sold Tales.
- **Fremont**: Mainly vintage fashion wear and not as eccentric as its neighbor, Ballard. It is also a center for antiques and accessories. The shopping district is centered around Fremont

Place N and N 35th Street.

- **International District:** Groceries, herbal medicines, and plenty of Asian-style wares. You can also buy handy Japanese kitchenware and other items at the widely-known Uwajimaya or by the back door of the dollar shop Daiso.
- **North Seattle:** Thrift stores scattered throughout the area, bulk grocery shopping at Aurora Avenue N, and big apparel stores at Northgate.
- **South Lake Union:** A long retail strip is on Westlake Ave, catering mostly to tech workers. Outdoor gear chain REI houses its flagship store on Stewart St.
- **University District:** Clothing and thrift stores catering to the local student population are along "The Ave", University Way. Upscale options are available at the open-air University Village Mall at 25th Ave NE.
- **West Seattle:** Head to California Ave SW for more laid back and contemporary clothing options.



Fresh produce at a farmers' market in Ballard. In the summer, Seattle has over a dozen weekly farmers' markets; Sunday in Ballard and Saturday in the University District are among the few year-round markets.

Groceries and other basics

The major supermarket chains in Seattle are QFC, Fred Meyer (both owned by Kroger) and Safeway. For housewares and general merchandise, look at Fred Meyer and Target. The city has many specialty and organic supermarket chains, with local chains Metropolitan Market and PCC (a grocery co-op), in addition to Trader Joe's and Whole Foods Market. You can find grocery stores catering to Seattle's large Asian immigrant communities, such as Uwajimaya (Japanese) in the International District, H-Mart (Korean) downtown and in the University District, and Asian Family Market (Chinese) in North Seattle. Costco has one store in the city, the chain's original warehouse in SoDo, with many more locations in the inner suburbs.

Farmers markets

Although Pike Place Market is steeped in history and always busy, locals don't buy much produce there. Dozens of neighborhood farmers markets dot the region, with many active only in the summer months (May-Oct). The primary neighborhood farmer markets in Seattle include: University District and Magnolia (Saturdays); Ballard, Capitol Hill, West Seattle (Sundays); City Hall (Tuesdays); Columbia City (Wednesdays); Lake City (Thursdays); and Phinney Ridge (Fridays).

Eat

Individual listings can be found in Seattle's [district articles](#)

Typical of a big city, Seattle has a diverse range of fare representative of cuisines from around the world. Local chains and hole-in-the-wall restaurants dominate the city's dining atmosphere, and hearty, inexpensive meals can be found all over the city.

This page uses the following price ranges for a typical meal *for one*, including soft drink:

Budget up to \$12

Local specialties

Mid-range	\$12-\$25
Splurge	more than \$25

Seattle's proximity to Alaska and the waters of the Pacific Ocean make it an excellent place to enjoy **seafood**. Look for **salmon** during the late summer months as options are abundant and the prices are among the cheapest on the West Coast, especially the red (sockeye) salmon. **Shellfish** are a prized resource of the Puget Sound, where the cool, clean waters provide an optimal habitat. Clams, mussels and oysters can be found easily, but other specialties like *geoducks* (pronounced GOO-ey-ducks) are sometimes available for the more adventurous. The **Dungeness crab**, named for a nearby town on the Sound, is a popular seafood prized for its sweet, tender flesh and high ratio of meat. The Dungeness is a commercially important crab in Washington's waters but other crab species are also common. The **Alaskan king crab**, caught from the deep cold waters of the Pacific Ocean near Alaska, has a more frequent presence here than the rest of the lower 48.

The mild climate also supports many types of fresh **produce**. Farmers' markets are a normal occurrence on the weekends, especially in residential areas, and they usually have better quality produce than what you can get at supermarkets. They're an excellent opportunity to taste local delicacies and experience the local culture. **Apples**, which are exported from Washington and shipped all over the world, are in season around September or October. Delicious **Rainier cherries** are in season June through early August.

Seattle boasts a wide variety of **Asian cuisine**, from East Asia to the South. For several decades the ubiquitous comfort food of choice was the Japanese-inspired **teriyaki**, a generous portion of grilled chicken in a sweet-savory sauce served over white rice. The family-run hole-in-the-wall shops offering this cheap and filling fast food are increasingly being displaced by more upmarket fare, giving way to the **poke** and **ramen** shops popping up across the city. **Sushi** is widely available, in quality (and price) ranging from pedestrian to exquisite. **Thai** cuisine is ubiquitous, Chinese restaurants are present in most neighborhoods, and more recent waves of immigrants have added Vietnamese pho and Korean influence to the landscape.

The **Cuban pork sandwich**, a non-traditional heap of roasted pork, grilled onions, and aioli dressing in an undersized crusty roll, is offered by several casual restaurants throughout the city. There are also a fair number of **Ethiopian** restaurants, with a large concentration in the Central District and South Seattle.

Donut shops and bakeries are virtually everywhere, with some offering warm in-house brewed coffee, making them an excellent delight in the cold weather or as a snack.

Eating options by district

Downtown and **Pioneer Square** feature high end restaurants and lounges, catering to office workers and event attendees. **Belltown** is home to most options for downtown dining, with restaurants in every price range and some of the city's best-reviewed restaurants. **Pike Place Market** and Post Alley are littered with street food, upscale cafes, and trendy dining. The **Waterfront**, naturally, has a selection of seafood restaurants. Food carts can be found at **Westlake Park** and **South Lake Union**, catering to workers wanting a quick and easy lunch.

Outside of Downtown, **Capitol Hill** is filled with hip cafés and bars, some of the trendiest restaurants in the city, as well as many Ethiopian and Thai eateries. The **International District** is known for dim-sum, Chinese and Japanese offerings, as well as Vietnamese

restaurants on the east side of the neighborhood. Near Seattle Center, **Queen Anne** seems to offer a little bit of everything.

North of the ship canal, **Ballard** has mostly European fare with some Mexican, Mediterranean, and Asian options. **Fremont** has a variety of upscale world cuisines in small establishments. The **University District** has a myriad of budget and international eateries, while **North Seattle** has some scattered family-run Asian restaurants.



The Chinatown Gate, entrance to the International District at S King Street

South Seattle has the greatest diversity of ethnic restaurants in Seattle, especially for African and Southeast Asian cuisine. **West Seattle** has elegant mid-range to high-end choices, mostly European, seafood, and steakhouses.

Neighboring Bellevue is also a dining hotspot, especially for authentic Chinese and Indian food, but tends to be expensive.

Drink

Individual listings can be found in Seattle's district articles

Few, if any, American cities can challenge Seattleites' love of **coffee**. This is perhaps best signified by the Seattle-based international chain Starbucks (<https://www.starbucks.com>), but locals aren't satisfied by recognized chains alone, as evidenced by the hundreds of good locally owned coffeehouses. The best places to look for coffee are in Capitol Hill or Queen Anne Hill, where they take matters of coffee *very* seriously. Local favorites include Cafe Ladro, Vivace, Victrola, Caffe Vita, and Zoka, all of whom do their own roasting. Seattle coffee shops have their own slang: drip-brewed coffee is called simply "drip", two shots of espresso in a cup is a "doppio", and a "shot in the dark" is a shot of espresso poured into a cup of coffee, for a boost of extra caffeine. Some independent shops offer free **cupping** (tasting) classes, to educate customers about specialty beans.

If you prefer **tea**, many coffee shops offer a selection of teas, and specialty tea shops offer a large catalog and can help you with recommendations. Like any other city with a large Asian population, **bubble tea** or **boba milk tea** shops exist, and are popular among young people. Bubble tea is basically milk tea with various flavors and tapioca balls. Many of these shops also offer Asian snacks and delicacies. If you are thirsty and hungry, and budget is your main concern, this can be a good option. Most of these can be found in the University District as well as a few in the International District.

Craft beer is a Northwest specialty. Washington State is one of the largest growers of hops in the world, and local brewers like to highlight this locally-sourced ingredient. Fresh hop season runs from mid-September to mid-October, when many breweries utilize fresh (not dried) hops for a uniquely local flavor. The larger brewers distribute their products regionally or nationally, while other brews can only be found in local stores or bars; some beers are only available on

draft, not in cans or bottles. Elysian (now owned by AB InBev), with three pubs, and the Pike Brewing Company in Pike Place Market, are popular local brewers. **Brewery tasting rooms** or **taprooms**, especially around Ballard but also in South Seattle and elsewhere, sell their beers directly to customers by the tasting glass, pint, 64-ounce (about 2 liter) growler, can, and keg. Taprooms are a particularly great option for families and on good weather days: many of them have enormous outdoor seating areas, most have no age restrictions, dogs are allowed, non-alcoholic beverages are also sold, and outside food is permitted. Many have menus for getting food delivered, and many have a rotating list of food trucks that sell food right outside.

In Washington, **bars** have a full liquor license, while **taverns** (which have become uncommon) are restricted to beer, wine and cider. Many Seattle bars have a world-class beer selection featuring local Northwest style micros, many of them crafted in Seattle. Bars and taverns are restricted to patrons 21 and older, and especially in Capitol Hill and the University District, all patrons may be asked to show ID, even if they are not drinking.

Wine is another Northwest specialty, and there are over 130 wineries just thirty miles from Seattle proper in Woodinville, though their vineyards are elsewhere in the state. Many more can be found a 2-3 hour drive away on the other side of the Cascades in Washington Wine Country, around Yakima and Walla Walla. You can find local vintages in grocery stores, wine shops, restaurants, and wine bars such as Bottlehouse and Purple.

Spirits are distilled in a few Seattle neighborhoods, including downtown, Georgetown, and Fremont. Distillery tasting rooms offer modestly-priced trials of whiskey, vodka, gin, and other spirits, either neat or in cocktails.

Washington state allows all alcoholic drinks to be sold at large supermarkets, so liquor is readily available even if you don't want to go to a bar. Drinking alcohol in public, including in parks and on public transportation, is illegal. Bars will not allow a drink, or even an empty container, to leave the premises. Tasting rooms that sell beer "to go" in cans, bottles, and growlers will not allow customers to consume that beer on site.

Sleep

Individual listings can be found in Seattle's district articles

For such a large city, there is a surprising lack of accommodation options available, thus rooms in Seattle are more on the expensive side. Most sleeping options are in Downtown and consist mostly of mid-range or high-end hotels. Other options, especially budget hotels and hostels can be found near the Seattle Center, the University District, the International District, and in North Seattle. There are also bed and breakfast options in Fremont, Ballard, and Capitol Hill. Some low-priced motels along Aurora Ave N are notoriously associated with prostitution, drug dealing, and other crimes; travelers primarily interested in sightseeing should look elsewhere.

This guide uses the following price ranges for a standard *double* room:

Budget	Less than \$150
Mid-range	\$150-\$250
Splurge	More than \$250

Alternatives to Seattle accommodations are a train ride away south in Tukwila and SeaTac, especially the areas surrounding the airport. Because of their proximity to light rail stations that offer a direct ride to major stadiums and arenas, airport-area hotels offer a frugal, traffic-free alternative for tourists in town for a sports or entertainment event. By SouthCenter Mall in Tukwila, there are more hotels to choose from with a wide range of rates. You can also find more options for hotels across the I-90 bridge in Bellevue or other towns on the other side of Lake Washington, such as Kirkland, Issaquah, or Renton.

Connect

By phone

The area code for the City of Seattle is **206**. Surrounding areas use other area codes, including **425** which encompasses the eastern and northern suburbs including Bellevue, Redmond, Lynnwood, and Everett, **253** for all areas south of Kent such as Tacoma, Federal Way, and Fife, and **360** for everywhere else west of the Cascades. All of Washington east of the Cascades uses the **509** area code. Ten-digit dialing is mandatory; in Seattle, if a phone number is listed as only seven digits, add 206 before it.

Prepaid mobile phones and SIM cards are sold at dedicated stores, kiosks, and at supermarkets and drugstores.

By Internet

The city maintains a map of public Wi-Fi sites (<https://seattle.gov/tech/internet-and-devices/free-public-wi-fi>). Good options include:

- **Seattle Public Library (<https://www.spl.org/>)** (SPL). All branches have open Wi-Fi, using the SSID **spl-public**. Public computers with Internet access and basic office software are available for up to 30 minutes for those without a SPL library card; get a temporary pass from the circulation desk. All services are free. Free. (updated Jun 2023 |)
- **Seattle Center**, as well as many other museums, sports venues, and cultural attractions.
- **RapidRide buses** and **Sounder commuter trains**.
- Community centers and offices for government services.
- Most coffee shops, and many restaurants.

Most major wireless carriers offer good 4G LTE and 5G coverage in the city, including in underground light rail stations.

Stay safe

Statistically, the crime in Seattle is similar to what you would expect in any major city in the United States. As long as you use some common sense, you are unlikely to be the target of a crime. Auto break-ins and theft are a notable problem, so never leave your valuables visible in a car and always lock your car doors.

Downtown Seattle has a sizable population of homeless people (many neighborhoods have forced their homeless into Seattle's downtown core). While many beg for change or seem unstable, only a few are actually dangerous. Some places to be careful near major tourist areas include 3rd Ave downtown (especially between Pine St. and Pike St.), around Pioneer Square, and the International District (especially near 12th Ave and Jackson St).

The rough parts of Seattle are fairly safe compared to the worst parts of other American cities, and you are unlikely to get into trouble by being in the wrong neighborhood during the day. However, there are areas to avoid walking around at night, including along Aurora Ave and Lake City Way in North Seattle, the International District, and parts of South Seattle.

On Friday and Saturday nights, take caution in the bar districts, including Belltown and the Pike/Pine corridor of Capitol Hill. You should be safe as long as you are not looking for trouble, but drunken and unruly behavior, in very rare cases, can lead to assault or shooting.

Drivers in Seattle are typically nice but indecisive. As long as you're careful as a pedestrian, you don't run a high risk of getting hit. Cyclists should be extra wary of traffic and opening doors of parked cars, especially Downtown.

Cannabis

See also: Washington (state) § Cannabis, and United States § Drugs

Recreational cannabis (marijuana) is legal to buy and consume in Washington state for persons 21 and older. (https://lcb.wa.gov/education/using_and_having_cannabis) There are plenty of dispensaries in Seattle to buy from.

- Purchasers are limited to one ounce of usable marijuana (the harvested flowers or "bud"), 16 ounces of marijuana-infused edibles in solid form, 72 ounces in liquid form, or 7 grams of marijuana concentrates.
- It is illegal to consume marijuana in public, including on public transportation and at street festivals. This law is not often enforced, although tourists may want to ask a local for advice before they attempt to consume.
- It is illegal to drive under the influence of THC. The DUI limit is 5.00 nanograms of THC per milliliter of blood.
- People may not transport marijuana out of the state or country, even if their destination has legalized it, may not take it on flights, and may not give it to a minor for consumption. This includes the Canadian border and Vancouver where cannabis is also legal, and includes neighboring Idaho where possession is highly illegal (punishable by a year in jail) and police target Washington cars in hopes of making a bust.
- Smoking and vaping of *any* substance, even tobacco, must be done at least 25 feet (about 8 meters) away from doors, windows, or ventilation shafts, and is prohibited in public parks.
- Regulations for alcohol often apply to marijuana as well.

Some of these rules are enforced more strictly than others. You are most likely to get in trouble for passing marijuana to someone under 21, or for driving under the influence.

Businesses, including bars, generally do not tolerate use on their premises, and are very likely to eject you, because you are putting their license at risk. Take your cues from the locals as to where smoking is informally accepted, and be polite about not lighting up in front of strangers who might object.

Weather

During fall through early spring, when the weather is said to be sunny, the morning often starts with fog before the afternoon sunshine clears it. Be careful if you're driving, as visibility can be near zero in the early morning, depending on the location. Watch out for black ice as well if the temperature is below freezing. Occasionally, this condition will persist for days and air quality will deteriorate as emissions will get trapped over the city; in these cases, an Air Stagnation Advisory and Burn Ban will be issued, and those with breathing problems should take precautions in such an event.

In case of rain, take the normal precautions while driving to avoid skidding; drive 10-15 mph slower than the speed limit and avoid driving through large puddles. If you are heading to the mountains in the winter, take the typical winter driving precautions, like putting chains on your tires or changing to traction tires. When it snows in Seattle, it is not recommended to drive, as the city is typically unprepared for such an event and motor vehicles become a moving hazard — stuck, skidding, or rolling down the city's hills.

LGBT

While Seattle's LGBTQ+ community is well-integrated throughout the entire city, Capitol Hill is the heart of Seattle's gay cultural scene and is a historical hub of gay and gay-friendly businesses, bars, restaurants and clubs. Its eclectic nightlife and central location make Capitol Hill the ideal place for an exciting night out. But more family-friendly gay activities can be found in other areas as Seattle has the second-largest percentage of gay, lesbian or bisexual residents among large cities in the U.S.

Natural disasters

Seattle infrequently experiences large **earthquakes**. The very infrequent Cascadia subduction zone earthquake will wreak havoc throughout the Pacific Northwest, but the occasional magnitude 7 quake on the Seattle Fault will cause more damage locally. The Downtown Waterfront, as well as the International District and SoDo, are built on fill that will become very unstable in a large quake.

Tsunamis pose a related danger. While the Puget Sound protects Seattle from threats on the open Pacific, a local earthquake or a landslide (which the region is prone to) could create a tsunami within the sound of up to 15 feet (5 m). If this happens, you would have *at most* a few minutes to evacuate. **As soon as an earthquake stops, move to high ground; if you can't, get to higher floors of a multi-story building.** The hilly topography provides plenty of high ground to escape to, but the entire shoreline (including the popular Downtown Waterfront) as well as SoDo and other areas near the mouth of the Duwamish River could be completely washed out.

Stay healthy

Smog can cover the skies of Puget Sound when high pressure causes still air, typically during the hottest days of summer and the (rare) sunny and dry days in winter, as there is no wind to clear out pollutants and moisture. If an Air Stagnation Advisory or Burn Ban is issued, take

precautions if you have breathing problems. On these days, consider heading to the mountains, where you're more likely to experience sunshine and slightly warmer temperatures.

Wildfire smoke sometimes drifts in, most often during August and September. If you have breathing problems, you should take precautions. Unfortunately, the usual remedy of heading to the mountains doesn't work.

Smoking is not allowed in any public places, and must be done at least 25 feet away from doors, windows, or ventilation shafts.

Tap water is safe to drink. It is among the best quality in the United States, from undisturbed and uncontaminated water sources fed by snow melt in the Cascade Mountains. It's probably better than your average bottled water!

Cope

Dress

Fashion in Seattle covers a wide range, from chic and stylish to flannel, grunge, and anti-fashion. In fact, it's hard to think of a style that wouldn't be acceptable somewhere in the city. Overall, though, dress is decidedly **casual**. In 2013, Seattle was ranked the most "dressed-down" city in the nation, preferring comfort over fashion. It's almost impossible to be underdressed in Seattle; even the Seattle Opera and Seattle Symphony encourage you to wear shorts and sandals if you're so inclined.

Dressing in **layers** is a good idea, due to unpredictable weather and differences in temperature from indoors to outdoors. Even during the summer months, cool temperatures are common in the morning, and it's always colder on and near the water than it is away from it. Practical accessories like **boots** and **scarves** are also common, depending on the season.

When it rains, Seattleites frequently **don't use umbrellas**, since the drizzle is constant and is sometimes accompanied with wind. Rather, the locals are more likely to wear a hooded jacket or a lightweight rain jacket, and packing one is recommended.

When the sun is out, many locals will eagerly break out shorts and sandals, even if the temperature is only in the 60s (16–21 °C). Because outdoor dining is available all year long, many restaurants and bars offer outdoor heaters; some provide free blankets.

Newspapers

- **The Seattle Times** (<https://www.seattletimes.com/>) (\$0.50 daily, \$1.50 Sundays) is the only remaining daily newspaper in the Seattle area and covers local, national and international news.
- The **Seattle Post-Intelligencer** (<https://www.seattlepi.com/>) (known as the "Seattle P-I" or simply the "P-I") (free, online only) has ended its print edition, but still maintains local reporters and an online presence.
- **The Stranger** (<https://www.thestranger.com/>) is an alternative newspaper noted for its social commentary, political opinion, arts, comics, music coverage, and local news items. It largely dropped its print edition early in the COVID-19 pandemic, although as of 2023 it has

revived a printed quarterly arts and entertainment issue. It retains a reasonably robust online presence.

- **Real Change** (<https://www.realchangenews.org/>) (minimum \$2.00, published Wednesday) is a newspaper about local news and issues relating to the homeless and poor. It's sold by homeless and low-income vendors on sidewalks as a source of income.

There are also several ethnic newspapers including *Northwest Asian Weekly* (<https://nwasianweekly.com/>) (strictly online since 2023, but still with a staff and with broader coverage than its name suggests), and numerous neighborhood newspapers including the *North Seattle Journal* and the *West Seattle Blog*. The University of Washington also publishes *The Daily of the University of Washington* (<https://www.dailyuw.com/>).

Radio

Seattle is in the top 20 of the largest media market in the US, thus virtually every genre you can think of has its own radio station:

- **KUOW (94.9)** (<https://www.kuow.org/>) = news & talk, NPR, PRI, BBC World Service. Broadcast from the University of Washington
- **KNKX (88.5)** = news & jazz, NPR (National Public Radio), PRI (Public Radio International)
- **KEXP-FM (90.3)** (<https://www.kexp.org/>) = alternative & indie rock, with a large number of live performances. Affiliated with NPR, but carries no national NPR programming.
- **KVTI (90.9)** = NPR, classical Music (Northwest Public Radio)
- **KIRO-FM (97.3)** (<https://mynorthwest.com/category/kiro-radio/>) = news, and a comprehensive traffic report.
- **KOMO-FM (97.7)** (<https://komonews.com/>) = news
- **KOMO (1000 AM)** = news

Television

Seattle is the 13th largest television market in the US, with all big five English (ABC, NBC, CBS, CW, FOX), four Spanish (Univision, Telemundo, Azteca, MundoFOX), and independent networks represented. All big five except CW, and Univision have local news, weather, and sports alongside syndicated & network primetime TV shows. You can also stream on their website when they broadcast local news.

- **KOMO** (<https://komonews.com/>) = Channel 4 (ABC)
- **KING** (<https://www.king5.com/>) = Channel 5 (NBC)
- **KIRO** (<https://www.kiro7.com/>) = Channel 7 (CBS)
- **KCTS** (<https://www.kcts9.org/>) = Channel 9 (PBS)
- **KCPQ** (<https://www.q13fox.com/>) = Channel 13 (FOX). Here is where you watch the Seahawks (Sunday games).
- **KBTC** (<https://www.kbtc.org/>) = Channel 28 (PBS)

Hospitals

Seattle has a lot of primary- and secondary-care medical centers, including the only level 1 trauma center serving Alaska, Washington, Idaho and Montana. Additionally, Children's Hospital and Regional Medical Center is the pediatric referral center for those same states. An

area roughly between I-5 and Broadway is dubbed as **Pill Hill** for having three of Seattle's largest medical centers within the small complex: Harborview, Virginia Mason, and Swedish.

- **UW Medicine (<https://www.uwmedicine.org/>)** The UW Medicine system is operated by the University of Washington. It includes Harborview Medical Center, UW Medical Center, UW Medicine Neighborhood Clinics, Eastside Specialty Center, Hall Health (Student Health Services) and Sports Medicine Clinic.
 - **Harborview Medical Center (<https://www.uwmedicine.org/locations/harborview-medical-center>)**, 325 Ninth Ave, ☎ +1 206-744-3000. Managed by the University of Washington Medicine system, it is Seattle's Level 1 trauma center, and the hospital where most critically injured patients are either airlifted or ambulated. 24-hour Emergency Room, Centers of Emphasis for neurosciences, trauma, burns, reconstruction and rehabilitation, mentally ill and medically vulnerable, and AIDS/STD treatment. Also has a center for sexual assault rehabilitation. (updated Oct 2015 |)
 - **UW Medical Center (<https://www.uwmedicine.org/locations/uw-medical-center>)**, 1959 NE Pacific St, ☎ +1 206-598-3300. The second hospital component to the UW Medicine system, this hospital is one of the biggest and best teaching hospitals in the country. 24-hour Emergency Room. (updated Oct 2015 |)
 - **Seattle Children's Hospital (<https://www.seattlechildrens.org/>)**, 4800 Sand Point Way NE, ☎ +1 206-987-2000. Children's Hospital is a private hospital specializing in pediatrics. It is also home to UW's School of Pediatrics. 24-hour pediatric emergency room. (updated Oct 2015 |)
- **Swedish Health Services (<https://www.swedish.org/>)** Swedish Medical Center is a large nonprofit health care provider. It has three main hospital locations and is also affiliated with many other suburban hospitals and clinics. Among the things Swedish is known for are its Cancer, Bariatrics and Heart Institutes. Swedish Hospital will treat all patients who need care, regardless of their ability to pay.
 - **Swedish Medical Center First Hill (<https://www.swedish.org/locations/first-hill-campus>)**, 747 Broadway, ☎ +1 206-386-6000. Certified Primary Stroke Care center, 24-hour ER, 24-hour Pediatric ER. This is the Main Swedish Medical Center campus and is the largest hospital in Seattle. (updated Oct 2015 |)
 - **Swedish Medical Center Cherry Hill (<https://www.swedish.org/locations/cherry-hill-campus>)**, 500 17th Ave., ☎ +1 206-320-2000. Certified Primary Stroke Care center, 24-hour ER.
 - **Swedish Medical Center Ballard (<https://www.swedish.org/locations/ballard-campus>)**, 5300 Tallman Ave NW, ☎ +1 206-782-2700. 24-hour ER.
- **Virginia Mason Medical Center (<https://www.virginiamason.org/>)**, 1100 Ninth Avenue, toll-free: +1-888-862-2737. One of the best hospitals in the state and the nation for cancer, heart diseases, gastro, and orthopedic surgery. It is also known for having a high satisfactory in patient care. (updated Oct 2015 |)

*In the event of a medical emergency anywhere in the U.S., dial **9-1-1** for free from any phone, including payphones at no cost.*

Consulates

Most consulates are honorary which means they offer limited services to travelers and their nationals living in the area and usually available by appointment only. They are typically in downtown but can be elsewhere too. The nearest cities for additional foreign consulates for the west coast are in Los Angeles and San Francisco:

-  **Austria (Honorary)** (<https://www.austrianconsulateseattle.org/>), ☎ +1 425-395-4382. (updated Oct 2017 |)
-  **Belgium (Honorary)** (<https://unitedstates.diplomatie.belgium.be/en>), The World Trade Center Seattle, 2200 Alaskan Way, Suite 470, ☎ +1 206-395-4487, consulbelseattle@gmail.com (<mailto:consulbelseattle@gmail.com>). By appointment only. Please contact the Consulate in Los Angeles (<https://unitedstates.diplomatie.belgium.be/en/embassy-and-consulates/consulate-general-los-angeles>) for passports, visas, and ID card inquiries. (updated Jun 2017 |)
-  **Cambodia (Honorary)** (<https://www.embassyofcambodiadc.org/>), 1818 Westlake Avenue N., Suite 315, ☎ +1 206-217-0830, fax: +1 206-361-7888, consul_huoth@diplomats.com (mailto:consul_huoth@diplomats.com). The Cambodia Embassy (<https://www.embassyofcambodiadc.org/how-to-get-a-visa.html>) in Washington DC offers same day visa processing on Wednesdays walk-in. It's 7-10 business days (from date of receipt) for mail/courier services excluding delivery times.
-  **Canada** (<https://www.international.gc.ca/country-pays/us-eu/seattle.aspx?lang=en>), Century Square @ 1501 4th Ave, Suite 600 (4th Ave & Pike), ☎ +1 206-443-1777, toll-free: +1-844-880-6519, fax: +1 206-443-9662, seatl@international.gc.ca (<mailto:seatl@international.gc.ca>). M-F 8AM-noon and 1-2:30PM by appointment only. Visa applications and residency permits are only processed by the consulates or VFS Global in Los Angeles (https://www.international.gc.ca/country-pays/us-eu/los_angeles.aspx?lang=eng), New York (https://www.international.gc.ca/country-pays/us-eu/new_york.aspx?lang=eng), or in your home country. Passports (<https://www.canada.ca/en/immigration-refugees-citizenship/services/canadian-passports.html>) are processed in Canada only:
 - **VFS Global** (<https://visa.vfsglobal.com/usa/en/can/>) (TT Services), 5757 Wilshire Blvd, Suite #500, Beverly Hills 90036, toll-free: +1 888 296-4511. M-F 9AM-5PM. VFS Global (TT Services) handles visa applications, criminal inadmissibilities, and applications for residency permits. Passport applications and renewals are handled directly from Canada or the IRCC office (consulate) in Los Angeles and New York. Click here (<https://www.canada.ca/en/immigration-refugees-citizenship/services/canadian-passports-usa.html>) to learn more. (updated Apr 2024 |)
-  **Cyprus (Honorary)** (<https://www.cyprusembassy.net/>), 5555 Lakeview Dr, Suite 200, Kirkland, WA 98033, ☎ +1 425 827-1700. (updated Jul 2024 |)
-  **El Salvador** (<https://rree.gob.sv>), Broderick Building, 615 2nd Ave, Suite 50, Seattle, WA 98104 (2nd Ave & Cherry), ☎ +1 206-971-7950, toll-free: +1 888-301-1130, fax: +1 206-236-5162, consuladoseattle@rree.gob.sv (<mailto:consuladoseattle@rree.gob.sv>). M-F 8AM to 4PM. See <https://portal citas.rree.gob.sv> to make appointment online.
-  **France (Honorary)** (<https://sanfrancisco.consulfrance.org/-english->), World Trade Center Seattle, 2200 Alaskan Way, Suite #490, ☎ +1 206-444-0097, seattle@agenceconsulaire.fr (<mailto:seattle@agenceconsulaire.fr>). Click here (<https://www.facebook.com/consulfranceSeattle>) for their Facebook page. (updated Jul 2016 |)
-  **Denmark (Honorary)** (<https://usa.um.dk/en/about-us/list-of-danish-honorary-consulates-in-the-us/seattle-washington>), 4702 SW Findlay St, Seattle WA 98136, ☎ +1 206-230-0888, fax: +1 206-389-1708, marksc@umgate.dk (<mailto:marksc@umgate.dk>). M-F 9AM - 5PM by appointment only.
-  **Estonia (Honorary)** (<https://washington.mfa.ee/estonian-honorary-consuls-in-usa/>), 950 N 72nd St Suite 100, Seattle, WA 98103, ☎ +1 206 310-2153, +1 206 284-4061, paul.raidna@gramorwa.com (<mailto:paul.raidna@gramorwa.com>).
-  **Germany (Honorary)** (<https://www.germany.info/us-en/hc-state-wa/905538>), mailing address @ 4701 SW Admiral Way, Suite #130, Seattle WA 98116, ☎ +1 206-589-8270, seattle@hk-diplo.de (<mailto:seattle@hk-diplo.de>). By appointment only. Appointments can be made on <https://www.yourseattle.de>.

-  **Guatemala** (<https://www.minex.gob.gt/>), 18000 International Blvd Suite #1005, SeaTac 98188- (10th floor of the South Tower. Across International Blvd from the airport.), ☎ +1 206-854-9975, toll-free: +1 206 888-5319, consseattle@minex.gob.gt (<mailto:consseattle@minex.gob.gt>). M-F 8AM-3PM. They also visit their nationals living in Oregon and other parts of Washington state in their "consulado movil" (mobile consulate) program to provide consular services and answer questions. Appointments can also be made at: <https://minex-gob-gt.my.site.com/pc/s/citas-consulares>. See also <https://www.facebook.com/ConsGtSeattle/> (on Facebook) to learn more as to what's happening at the local consulate in Seattle. (updated Jul 2018 |)
-  **Honduras** (<https://citaconsularhn.com/seattle/>), Global Credit Union Financial Center Bldg, 1107 SW Grady Way Suite #100, Renton (*Global Credit Credit Union Bldg at SW Grady Way and Oaksdale Ave SW*), ☎ +1 206 420-0947. M-F 9AM - 2PM. They have their own Facebook page (<https://www.facebook.com/consuladogeneraldehondurasenseattle/>) to announce the happenings of the local consulate in Seattle and on <https://citaconsular.sreci.gob.hn/citaconsular/pages/layout/CitaConsular.php> to make an appointment. (updated Jul 2018 |)
-  **India** (<https://indiainseattle.gov.in/>), CTi BioPharma Building, 3101 Western Ave, Suite 700, Seattle WA 98121 (*CTi BioPharma Bldg on Western Ave & Bay St*), ☎ +1 206 803-0400. M-F 10AM-noon. (updated Jul 2024 |)
-  **Ireland (Honorary)** (<https://www.ireland.ie/en/usa/washington/contact/>), ☎ +1 206 351-1046, Bernard.hensey@honoraryconsul.ie (<mailto:Bernard.hensey@honoraryconsul.ie>). M-F By appointment only.
-  **Italy (Honorary)** (<https://www.casaitalianacc.org/italian-honorary-consulate-seattle/>), 13028 1st Ave S, Burien, ☎ +1 206 765-8584, seattle.onorario@gmail.com (<mailto:seattle.onorario@gmail.com>). By appointment only. (updated Jul 2024 |)
-  **Japan** (<https://www.seattle.us.emb-japan.go.jp/>), One Convention Place @ 701 Pike St, Suite 1000 (*Next to Convention Center on 7th & Pike, up on the 10th floor*), ☎ +1 206-682-9107, fax: +1 206-624-9097, info@cgjapansea.org (<mailto:info@cgjapansea.org>). M-F 9AM-11:30AM and 1PM-4:30PM. Their services also extend to other parts of Washington state, northern Idaho and Montana.
-  **Luxembourg (Honorary)** (<http://sanfrancisco.mae.lu>), 812 Warren Ave N (3 blocks north of Seattle Center between Valley & Aloha St), ☎ +1 206-956-9137. (updated Jul 2016 |)
-  **Mexico** (<https://consulmex.sre.gob.mx/seattle/>), Harvard Exit Theater @ 807 E Roy St (*One block west of Broadway at E Roy & Harvard. Entrance facing Harvard Ave E*), ☎ +1 206-448-3526, toll-free: +1-877-639-4835, fax: +1 206-448-4771, conseattle@sre.gob.mx (<mailto:conseattle@sre.gob.mx>). M-F 8:30AM-5PM, By appointment only. Contact +1 424 309-0009 on WhatsApp to make an appointment. See also <https://miconsulado.sre.gob.mx/> for online consular information (including visas) and to locate another consulate.
-  **Nepal** (<https://nepalconsulate.org/>), Bellevue Rechnology Center, 2018 156th Ave NE, Suite #126, Bellevue WA 98007, ☎ +1 206 324-9000. (updated Jul 2024 |)
-  **New Zealand (Honorary)** (<https://www.mfat.govt.nz/en/countries-and-regions/americas/united-states-of-america/new-zealand-consulate-general-los-angeles/>), 4010 Lake Washington Blvd NE, Suite 300, Kirkland, ☎ +1 425 829-4568, NZHonConSeattleWA@outlook.com (<mailto:NZHonConSeattleWA@outlook.com>). By appointment only.. By appointment only for Notarial and document certification services. Passport (<https://www.passport.govt.nz/>) and visa services (<https://www.immigration.govt.nz/>) are only handled from New Zealand. (updated Dec 2023 |)
-  **Norway (Honorary)** (<https://www.norway.no/en/usa/norway-usa/honorary-consulate-s/#Washington>), 1812 Hewitt Ave, Suite 211, Everett WA 98201, ☎ +1 425-337-5175, norwayconsulatewa@invisibleinch.com (<mailto:norwayconsulatewa@invisibleinch.com>).
-  **Peru (Honorary)** (<https://www.consulado.pe/es/SanFrancisco/Paginas/Inicio.aspx>), 3717 NE 157th St (*Off of NE Bothell Way*), ☎ +1 206-714-9037, consuladoperu@msn.com

(mailto:consuladoperu@msn.com). M W F 10:30AM to 5PM (by appointment only).

-  **Russia (<https://washington.mid.ru/en/>)**, Samuel Hyde House at 3726 E Madison (Madison & 38th Ave E), ☎ +1 202 939-8907, fax: +1 202 298-5735, consul@seanet.com (mailto:consul@seanet.com). Due to tensions between U.S. and Russian relations the consulate remains closed since 2018. Phone number in the above is to their consulate in Washington DC. ILS USA has been designated to help with the visa applications as an agent to the Russian government. See below:
 - **ILS USA (<https://ils-usa.com/news/175?domain=5&language=10>)**, 2226 Elliot Ave, Suite 'A', ☎ +1 202 436-4555. By appointment only. Inquire with regarding visas for Belarus, China, Mongolia and India as well. (updated Jan 2026 |)
-  **South Korea (<https://overseas.mofa.go.kr/us-seattle-ko/index.do>)**, 115 W Mercer St, ☎ +1 206-441-1011, fax: +1 206-441-7912, seattle0404@mofat.go.kr (mailto:seattle0404@mofat.go.kr). M-F 8:30AM-4PM.
-  **Sweden (Honorary) (<https://www.consulateofswedenseattle.com/>)**, c/o Hilleberg the Tent Maker, 17280 Woodinville-Redmond Rd NE, Suite 803, Woodinville WA 98072 (*Inside the Offices of Hilleberg the Tentmaker*), ☎ +1 425-952-6299, fax: +1 425-576-5400, seattle@consulateofsweden.org (mailto:seattle@consulateofsweden.org). If required, visas are applied through VFS Global (<https://visa.vfsglobal.com/usa/en/swe/>).
-  **Switzerland (Honorary) (<https://www.eda.admin.ch/countries/usa/en/home/representations/embassy-washington/honorary-consulates.html>)**, 6920 94th Ave SE, Mercer Island 98040-5442, ☎ +1 206-228-8110, seattle@honrep.ch (mailto:seattle@honrep.ch). This representation supports Swiss citizens who find themselves in need because of illness, an accident or theft while travelling. It also informs the responsible Swiss representation. This representation does not issue visas or (Swiss) passports. (updated Jul 2018 |)
-  **Taiwan (https://www.roc-taiwan.org/ussea_en/index.html)** (Taipei Economic & Cultural Office (TECO)), One Union Square @ 600 University St, Suite 2020, Seattle WA 98101, ☎ +1 206-441-4586, infoseattle@mofa.gov.tw (mailto:infoseattle@mofa.gov.tw). M-F 9AM-Noon.
-  **Thailand (Honorary) (<https://www.thai-or.com/>)**, 1136 NW Hoyt St Ste 210, Portland, ☎ +1 503-221-0440, fax: +1 503-221-0550, thai@siaminc.com (mailto:thai@siaminc.com). (updated Jul 2022 |)
-  **United Kingdom Government Office (Honorary) (<https://www.gov.uk/world/organisations/british-consulate-general-san-francisco/office/uk-government-office-seattle>)** (British Consulate San Francisco), Westin Building @ 2001 6th Ave, Suite 2600, Seattle WA 98121, ☎ +1 206 441-7144. M-F 9AM-4PM (By appointment only). The UK Government Office in Seattle works to promote business, economic and political ties with Washington State. Call +1 415 617-1300 for emergencies. (updated Jul 2024 |)
 - **VFS Services (USA) (<https://visa.vfsglobal.com/usa/en/gbr/attend-centre/seattle>)**, Active Voice Bldg @ 2033 6th Ave, Suite 993. M-F 8AM-4PM; 9AM-3PM for passport applications. VFS Global in Seattle handles the intake and processing of the UK visa, passport, and overseas British Citizenship applications. (updated Jul 2024 |)

Go next

Within the metropolitan area

- Edmonds — a few miles north, the lively waterfront town that travel legend Rick Steves calls home.
- Everett in the North Sound — about 25 miles north, home to a massive Boeing factory, where many of its wide-bodied aircraft are assembled.
- Tacoma in the South Sound — one hour south, where you can find one of the largest zoos in the country, as well as history and art museums.
- Bellevue — across Lake Washington, Seattle's largest suburb features posh shops and restaurants.
- Redmond — across Lake Washington, the home of Microsoft and Nintendo of America.

Across the water

Take a scenic ferry ride to the communities across the Puget Sound:

- Bainbridge Island (35 minutes one way) — a bedroom community with a lovely little commercial district and lots of preserved green space.
- Bremerton and the Kitsap Peninsula (60 minutes one way) — a suburban community with a large naval base.
- Vashon Island (20 minutes one way)
- Port Orchard (30-40 minutes one way)
- Victoria and Vancouver Island, British Columbia, Canada (2 hr 45 min, plus time to pass through border) — BC's compact and historic capital.

Day trips

Just getting out and driving around the area with no destination in mind can be a great experience, as the Seattle area, like most of the Pacific Northwest, is very scenic. If you'd like more specific destinations, try some of these:

- Olympic Peninsula — wild beaches on the Pacific Ocean, Cape Flattery (the extreme northwestern point of the contiguous U.S.), and some of the only temperate rain forests in the lower 48 states at the Olympic National Park.
- Portland, Oregon — three hours south, noted for its rose gardens. It's the largest city in the U.S. without a sales tax.
- Whidbey Island — 1-2 hours north, a charming place with quaint towns.
- Mount Vernon and Bellingham — two small towns 1-2 hours north. Every start of spring, the tulip fields near Mount Vernon pop up with vibrant colors and are a major tourist attraction.
- San Juan Islands — two hours north, the most immersive Salish Sea experience.
- Vancouver, Canada — three hours (plus border security) north, Canada's principal west coast city.

Cascade Mountains

- The Mountains to Sound Greenway via I-90 is the quickest escape into the mountains.

- Snoqualmie — with the scenic 300-foot-high (90 m) Snoqualmie Falls.
- North Bend — where parts of the 1990 David Lynch TV series *Twin Peaks* were filmed.
- The North Cascade Loop — a road trip over Stevens Pass (US-2) and through North Cascades National Park.
- Leavenworth — a Bavarian-style town on the east side of the Cascades.
- Mount Rainier National Park — two hours southeast, this magnificent mountain offers a mosaic of beautiful scenery such as blooming wildflowers, glaciers, crashing waterfalls and the mountain itself.
- Mount St. Helens — three hours south, mountain wilderness spoiled only by the massive 1980 eruption.

Winter sports

The Cascades boast several ski resorts within a few hours' drive. Enjoy everything from leisure snowball fights to downhill skis, a perfect escape if you are bored with rain. Winter sports season is generally November–May, depending on how much snow there is.

- Snoqualmie Pass — one hour east on I-90, the closest ski resort to Seattle. Elevation 2,610–5,420 ft (800–1,650 m).
- Stevens Pass — about two hours east of Seattle on Highway 2. Elevation 3,500–5,089 ft (1,067–1,551 m).
- Crystal Mountain — just east of Mount Rainier, with close-up views of the big mountain. Elevation 4,400–7,012 ft (1,341–2,137 m).
- Mount Baker — near Bellingham, holder of the world record for most snowfall. Elevation 3,500–5,089 ft (1,067–1,551 m).
- Mission Ridge — on the eastern slopes, with more sunshine than the other resorts. Elevation 4,570–6,820 ft (1,390–2,080 m)
- White Pass — a relaxed atmosphere for all abilities. Elevation 4,500–6,550 ft (1,370–2,000 m)
- Whistler, British Columbia, Canada — North America's largest and top rated ski resort, about a 4-5 hour drive north of Seattle past Vancouver on the Sea-to-Sky Highway.

